Bridging the Value Gap: Strategic Innovation for M&M's in the Dutch Market

Project 2: Research & Creativity

Fontys University of Applied Sciences



Prepared by: Project Group 2

Amira Kartika Rochman (5793351)

Jessie Ozinci (5730066)

Liza Boender (5786398)

Lydia Sagri (5819733)

Manar Alsadi (5904242)

Commissioning Party: Mars Inc.

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Abstract

This report addresses a critical "Value Gap" facing Mars Inc. in the Dutch market, where consumers increasingly favor Albert Heijn and Jumbo private-label chocolate alternatives. This shift is primarily driven by high price sensitivity and a perceived taste parity; initial field research involving 64 respondents across multiple age groups identified an 82% taste similarity between M&M's and store brands. While the data represents a broad consumer base, the findings highlight that the 18–30 demographic is the most volatile group, accounting for 70% of the sample and exhibiting the highest tendency to switch brands due to price. The objective of this research is to develop a strategic innovation that transitions the brand from a commodity product to an experience-based value proposition to justify its premium pricing and strengthen its category position through 2028.

The methodology utilized a Design Thinking framework, beginning with a divergent ideation phase that generated 200 unique concepts. These ideas were filtered through a COCD Box matrix to identify the most innovative and feasible solutions. The resulting "Play & Share" integrated board game concept was selected for its ability to transform the consumption moment into a unique social ritual.

This concept was subsequently validated through Lean Experiments with 17 respondents specifically from the 18–30 target demographic. Quantitative results demonstrate strong social appeal, achieving a mean score of 4.08 out of 5.0, and a 76.5% success rate in justifying the product's price premium over private-label competitors.

During the validation phase, qualitative findings indicated that 35% of participants held hygiene concerns regarding the use of food as game pieces. This triggered a strategic pivot to the "Colour Ownership" rule in the final prototype, ensuring players only interact with designated candies. This study concludes that the "Play & Share" concept effectively differentiates the brand through a unique social ritual, successfully justifying a 140% price premium over private-label competitors.

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Introduction

The Commissioning Party

This report details a strategic innovation initiative for Mars Inc., a global leader in the Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) sector. Managing a portfolio of iconic brands including M&M's and Maltesers, Mars operates under a corporate philosophy defined by the "Five Principles": Quality, Responsibility, Mutuality, Efficiency, and Freedom. The project was formalized in November 2025 following a professional consultation with Pepijn Lansbergen, (Assistant) Account Manager for Albert Heijn and Jumbo at Mars Inc., who provided the foundational business requirements for this research.

The Problem Definition

The primary motivation for this research is a measurable decline in market share for A-brands within the Dutch chocolate bites category. Despite maintaining a dominant 78% "share of heart" in aspirational preference, Mars is losing "share of wallet" to supermarket private labels (PL) at Albert Heijn and Jumbo. This trend is driven by a critical "Value Gap"—the perceived similarity in taste (82% similarity rating) contrasted with the significant price premium of M&M's—which has made traditional brand positioning vulnerable to price-sensitive consumers.

Purpose of the Assignment

The objective of this project is to bridge this gap by transitioning Mars products from a commodity-based snack into an experience-based value proposition. To strengthen Mars' category position through **2028**, the report addresses the following strategic requirements:

- **Behavioural Insight**: Determine why consumers prioritize private labels over A-brands during the shopping journey.
- **Strategic Differentiation:** Developing a concept that justifies the price premium through unique consumer utility.
- **Practical Implementation**: Generate a concrete, visual, and implementable marketing concept that respects Mars' current operational limitations.

Methodology and Scope

To achieve these goals, the group utilized the **Design Thinking framework**, moving systematically through the Empathize, Define, Ideate, Prototype, and Validate phases. The scope is strictly retail-focused, centering on the Dutch supermarket environment and the specific motivations of young adults and budget-conscious shoppers. The final output provides a validated concept designed to transform the consumption moment into a social ritual that private labels cannot replicate.

Chapter 1: Empathize — Desk Research

1.1 Introduction

Chocolate has never been more popular, yet well-known brands are losing ground.

In Dutch supermarkets, consumers increasingly reach for cheaper private label alternatives, even while expressing strong emotional attachment to iconic brands such as M&M's and Maltesers. This paradox reveals a growing tension between desire and affordability: consumers want premium experiences, but everyday budgets force rational compromises.

This report investigates tension by combining desk research with primary field research to understand why consumers switch, when they remain loyal, and what value they are truly seeking. Through market analysis, competitor evaluation, and consumer insights, the study uncovers the underlying value gap shaping today's chocolate-buying behavior and sets the foundation for opportunity-driven concept development.

1.2 Summary

This report explores consumer decision-making in the chocolate-bites category, focusing on the growing shift from A-brands to supermarket private labels. By combining desk research with survey-based field research among Dutch consumers, the study identifies key market trends, customer pains, jobs, and gains. The findings reveal a clear divide between functional, social, and emotional value, providing strategic insight into where well-known brands lose relevance—and where they still strongly win.

1.3 Desk Research: Market Trends & The Value Gap

This section explores the macro-environmental factors influencing the chocolate market, focusing on the tension between premium aspirations and economic reality.

1.3.1 The Rise of Private Label (PL) and the Value Gap

The global chocolate market is substantial, valued at approximately USD 123.05 billion in 2024 and projected to reach USD 184.69 billion by 2033 (Grand View Research, 2025). While the

market is growing, premium A-brands face intense pressure from private label (PL) competitors, which thrive on providing perceived value.

- **Price as the Top Driver:** Price is one of the top two purchase criteria for roughly 67% of survey respondents (see Appendix B, Table B3, p.68), and 42% report needing to carefully consider price when buying groceries (see Appendix B, Table B11, p.76). The qualitative data confirms that consumers primarily switch to PL because it is "Cheaper and almost the same taste" (see Appendix C, Table C1, p.77).
- **Perceived Taste Parity:** The most significant threat to Mars is the perceived taste similarity between A-brands and PL A striking 82% of respondents who have tried both rate the taste as at least *somewhat similar*, and nearly 40% rate it as *very similar or almost the same* (see Appendix B, Table B9, p.74). This narrow-perceived gap in quality makes the price premium difficult to justify for routine purchases (see Appendix C, Table C1, p.77).
- **Premium PL Expansion:** The premium chocolate segment itself is thriving, expected to increase by USD 20.8 billion by 2028 at a Compound Annual Growth Rate (CAGR) of 9.48% (Technavio, 2024). However, PL is capturing a share of this segment by offering products with enhanced quality and ethical sourcing at competitive prices (MarkNtel Advisors, 2024; Technavio, 2024). The entire market is shifting, with the market value expected to rise from USD 167.0 Billion in 2025 to USD 219.9 Billion by 2034 (IMARC Group, 2025).

1.3.2 Sustainability, Ethics, and Transparency

Ethical sourcing and environmental impact have become critical differentiators in the premium sector (Technavio, 2024; ZipDo Education Reports, 2025). This trend offers a route for A-brands to justify their higher cost:

- **Willingness to Pay:** A majority of European consumers, 70%, factor sustainability into their chocolate purchases (Confectionery Production, 2022). Furthermore, 68% of consumers globally express a willingness to pay more for chocolate products made with sustainable cocoa (Cargill, 2020; Confectionery Production, 2022). This willingness can be quantified, with consumers prepared to pay an average of 9.7% more for sustainably produced or sourced goods, even amidst inflationary concerns (PwC, 2024).

- **Focus on Cocoa Sourcing:** The demand for sustainably sourced cocoa is projected to increase by over 50% by 2025 (ZipDo Education Reports, 2025). Consumer concerns focus on deforestation, low farmer incomes, and child labor in cocoa farming (Technavio, 2024; ZipDo Education Reports, 2025).
- **Brand Trust:** While only 5% of total respondents prioritized sustainability as a top purchase factor, the high market share of a brand like Tony Chocolonely (17% of normal purchases) confirms that a strong, ethical platform can successfully support a premium price point (see Appendix B, Table B1, p.65).

1.3.3 Health, Clean Label, and Functional Indulgence

Changing consumer preferences are driving demand for healthier chocolate options (MarkNtel Advisors, 2024; Jacobo-Velázquez et al., 2021).

- **Clean Label Trend:** The confectionery market is seeing a growing demand for clean label sweets, which are characterized by shorter ingredient lists, natural coloring, and fewer artificial additives (Torg, 2025). Consumers prioritize simple, recognizable ingredients and transparency regarding sourcing (Innova Market Insights, 2025; Holt, 2025). The global clean label products market is projected to expand from USD 425.32 billion in 2025 (Towards FnB, 2025).
- **Functional Positioning:** A-brands can utilize functional ingredients to justify a premium (Tuigunov et al., 2025). Cocoa itself contains bioactive components, such as polyphenols, dietary fiber, and minerals, which are linked to cardiovascular, cognitive, and anti-inflammatory benefits (Katz et al., 2011; Jacobo-Velázquez et al., 2021). Modern innovations include fortifying chocolate with components like probiotics, prebiotics, and alternative plant milk to enhance nutritional value (Tuigunov et al., 2025).

1.3.4 Premiumization and Experience

Mars retains a key advantage in the realm of emotional and experiential value.

- **Emotional & Aspirational Preference:** Mars still owns the aspirational space, as an overwhelming 78% of respondents choose M&M's or Maltesers when the price is removed (see Appendix B, Table B10, p.75).
- **Occasion-Based Gifting:** Consumers naturally use A-brands for special occasions or parties (39% preference), acknowledging their role as a more "safe," recognizable, and premium gift or sharing moment (see Appendix B, Table B6, p.71). The purchase of premium chocolate is frequently driven by its suitability as a gift for special occasions (Technavio, 2024).
- **Experiential Innovation:** The market favors brands that offer unique experiences, high-quality cocoa, and exquisite ingredients (IMARC Group, 2025; Technavio, 2024). Brands that invest in innovation can attract younger audiences and drive demand for higher-priced goods (IMARC Group, 2025; Technavio, 2024).

1.4 Competitors Analysis

The chocolate-bites category is fragmented, with the top four brands/segments collectively accounting for 86% of the normal purchase share among respondents. The primary competitive threat to Mars' brands (M&M's/Maltesers) comes from two distinct types of competitors: aggressive Private Label alternatives (PL) and niche, mission-led A-brands.

1.4.1 Primary Direct Competitor: Albert Heijn/Jumbo Private Label

Private label brands are Mars' most significant challenger, leveraging a powerful Value Parity strategy.

- **Core Advantage: Price/Value:** PL products are commonly priced 15% to 40% lower than national brands, and the survey confirms consumers switch primarily because they perceive a "Cheaper and almost the same taste" (SciELO, 2016; see Appendix C, Table C1, p.77). Private labels are seen as the rational choice for everyday, routine purchases (see Appendix B, Table B5, p.70).

- **Evolving Quality and Differentiation:** Modern retailers are enhancing PL quality to build loyalty and differentiate their stores (ResearchGate, 2025; Hames Chocolates, 2024). They now offer specialized products—such as organic, vegan, and ethically sourced chocolates—that were once exclusive to premium A-brands, providing better value for money and catering to niche markets (Fortune Business Insights, 2024; CBI, 2019). This strategic development means PL is no longer just competing on low price but on affordable quality (McKinsey, 2024).

1.4.2 A-Brand Competitors: Milka and Tony Chocolonely

A. Milka

Milka, owned by Mondelez International, competes in the same mainstream premium segment as Mars and focuses on Emotional Positioning to attract consumers (Seedtag, 2024).

- **Core Advantage:** Tenderness and Heritage: Milka's positioning is built on the concept of "softness, creaminess, and comfort" and aiming to create "delicious moments of joy" (Seedtag, 2024; Prezi, 2014).
- **Key Assets:** The brand utilizes strong, consistent visual assets, including the iconic lilac packaging and the purple cow, which evoke "tender emotions" and associate the product with the quality and authenticity of Alpine milk (GitHub Pages, 2017; Prezi, 2014). The strategy focuses on reinforcing mental availability and emotional relevance (Seedtag, 2024).

B. Tony Chocolonely

Tony Chocolonely is a strong challenger brand that successfully built a large consumer base (see Appendix B, Table B1, p.65) by focusing on Ethical Leadership, positioning it outside the traditional price/taste debate.

- **Core Advantage:** Mission-Driven Ethics: Tony's mission is to make 100% slave-free chocolate the norm, using a unique 5 Sourcing Principles framework that goes beyond simple Fairtrade certification (Tony's Chocolonely NL, N/A; The Challenger Project, 2018).
- **Key Principles:** These principles include ensuring 100% traceable cocoa and paying an additional Living Income Reference Price (LIRP) premium to farmers on top of the

farmgate price, directly addressing the systemic cause of labor exploitation (Tony's Chocolonely Global, N/A; IESE Insight, 2025).

- **Strategy:** Tony's strategy introduced a new criteria of choice ("slave free"), allowing the brand to gain market share based on shared consumer values rather than traditional advertising (The Challenger Project, 2018; Acclym, 2024).

1.5 Target Group Description (Core Shopper Profile)

The target group for this analysis is a mixed sample of 64 supermarket shoppers in the Netherlands, providing indicative insights into the chocolate-bites category (see Appendix A, p.62). This group is characterized by a significant bias toward young, working adults who exhibit high price sensitivity but retain strong emotional loyalty to A-brands.

1.5.1 Core Demographics

- **Age Profile:** The sample is heavily skewed toward young adults, with the 18-30 age brackets accounting for 70% of all respondents (see Appendix A, Table A2, p.63). This includes 20% aged 18-20, 27% aged 21-25, and 23% aged 26-30.
- **Profession:** The majority of the target group are either Employees (47%) or Students (34%), totaling 81% of the sample (see Appendix A, Table A3, p.64).
- **Gender:** The sample is predominantly female (59%) compared to male (39%) (see Appendix A, Table A1, p.62).

1.5.2 Key Psychographics and Behavior

- **Price Sensitivity:** A significant minority, 42%, self-report needing to "carefully consider what I buy; price is very important" when grocery shopping (see Appendix B, Table B11, p.76). This price-constrained group is the most likely to drive the switch to Private Label (PL) options.
- **Switching Behavior:** The core purchasing pattern is one of hybridity, where consumers appreciate A-brands but are easily swayed by price: 44% of respondents prefer well-known brands but "will buy Supermarket brands... if it's cheaper" (see Appendix B, Table B4, p.69).

- **Aspirational Preference:** Despite rational price sensitivity, Mars maintains a dominant emotional position. When the price is removed from the equation, an overwhelming 78% of the target group choose M&M's or Maltesers (see Appendix B, Table B10, p.75), confirming they are the aspirational choice.
- **Consumption Frequency:** Chocolate is a regular purchase, but not a daily one, with 38% buying "A few times a month" (see Appendix B, Table B2, p.67). This high frequency contributes to rational search for everyday value.

Chapter 2: Define – Field Research & Customer Analysis

2.1 Introduction: Contextualizing the Define Phase

This chapter constitutes the "Define" phase of the Design Thinking process. Following the initial "Empathize" phase—which established the market landscape and broad consumer trends—this section narrows the analytical lens to a rigorous examination of Customer Jobs, Pains, and Gains.

The "Define" phase is pivotal as it transitions the research from observation to synthesis. While the preceding market analysis identified *what* is happening (e.g., market share erosion to Private Label), this analysis seeks to understand *why* it is happening at a behavioural and psychological level. By applying the **Jobs to Be Done (JTBD)** theoretical framework to primary data collected from 64 Dutch consumers, this report identifies the specific tasks consumers "hire" chocolate products to perform and exposes the structural "Value Gap" driving the current shift in market share.

2.2 Preparation and Execution of Field Research

To gain a deeper understanding of consumer behaviour within the chocolate bites category, a structured field research approach was executed. The objective was to identify the key motivations, pains, gains, and customer jobs that influence the choice between A-brands (such as M&M's and Maltesers) and supermarket private label alternatives.

2.2.1 Methodology and Data Collection

Based on the research guidelines, a quantitative survey with qualitative elements was selected as the primary research method. This hybrid approach allowed the project group to collect measurable data while capturing rich, open-ended explanations behind consumer choices.

- **Survey Design:** The survey was designed using Google Forms and followed a logical progression: general buying behaviour, price sensitivity, taste perception, and occasion-based consumption. Neutral wording was used to avoid steering respondents (see Appendix A, p.62).
- **Methodological Innovation (Instructor Commendation):** A critical inclusion in the research design was the **"Free Choice Scenario" (Question 10)**: *"If you could get one of these chocolate bites bags for free, which product group would you choose?"*.

This question was identified by the instructor as a "best practice" for isolating brand aspirations from price bias. Its success in revealing the strategic "Value Gap" led to its official recommendation as a model for other project groups to adopt in their own field research. Detailed results and insights from this question are analyzed in Figure B10 (Appendix B, p.75).

- **Sampling:** A convenience sampling method was utilized, reaching respondents through digital channels (WhatsApp, social networks) and face-to-face distribution.
- **Respondent Profile (N=64):** The sample represents a realistic cross-section of the target market. It consists of a balanced gender distribution (59% Female, 39% Male) and a mix of students and working adults (see Appendix A, Tables A1, p.62 and A3, p.64).
    - **Constraint:** Crucially, **42% of respondents** indicated they must "carefully consider" their grocery spending (see Appendix B, Table B11, p.76), highlighting the relevance of price sensitivity.
    - **Experience**: 70% of respondents have tried both A-brands and Private Labels (see Appendix B, Table B7, p.72), making their comparative insights highly valid.

2.3 Main Findings: The Consumer Reality

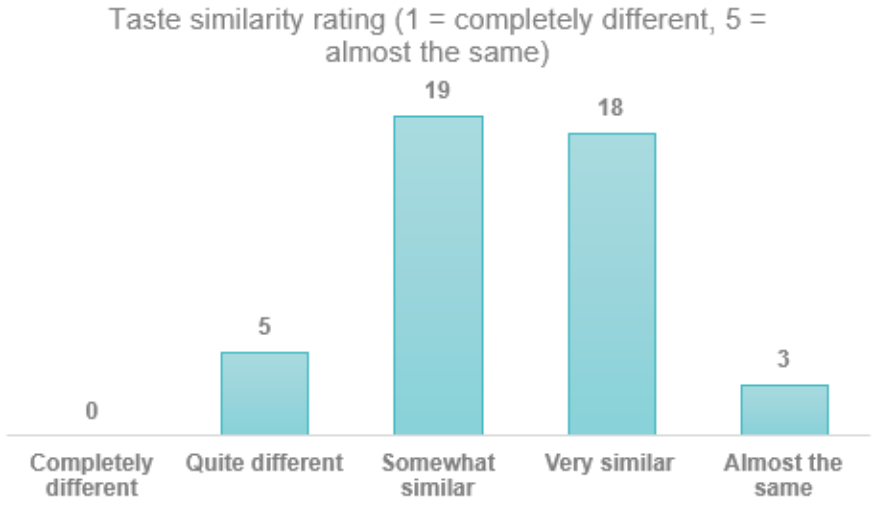
The analysis of the primary data reveals a "Bifurcation of Value." Consumers are highly rational regarding functional needs but remain emotional regarding social aspirations.

2.3.1 Main Consumer Pains

Three dominant pains explain why Mars is losing market share in everyday purchase situations:

1. **High Price Sensitivity:** Price is the dominant decision factor, with 67% of respondents selecting it as one of the two top considerations when choosing chocolate (see Appendix B, Table B3, p.68). Open-ended responses were dominated by "Lower price / saving money" as the primary reason for choosing Private Label (PL). This aligns with external research highlighting price consciousness as a key driver in chocolate buying decisions (Kiss et al., 2022).
2. **Perceived Taste Similarity:** A critical pain for Mars is that "Quality" is no longer a clear differentiator. **82% of consumers** rated the taste of A-brands and PL as "Somewhat similar," "Very similar," or "Almost the same" (Figure 2.1)**.** This perception weakens the justification for paying a premium (Kiss et al., 2022).

Figure 2.1: *Consumer Perception of Taste Similarity Between A-Brands and Private Label.*



Note. Respondent ratings of taste similarity on a scale from 1 (Completely different) to 5 (Almost the same).

3. **Limited Everyday Justification:** Consumers struggle to justify the premium price for daily snacking. A-brands are viewed as "nice but not necessary," while PL is perceived as "good enough" (see Appendix C, Table C1, p.77 and C4, p.81) for the functional job of snacking.

2.3.2 Customer Jobs to Be Done (JTBD)

Using the JTBD framework (Christensen et al., 2016), three distinct dimensions of the "Job" consumers hire chocolate to perform were identified.

1. Functional Job: "Caloric & Economic Optimization"

This job is characterized by the consumer's need to satisfy a craving or hunger pang with the highest possible efficiency. Efficiency here is defined by the ratio of Sensory Output (Taste) to Financial Input (Price).

Data Analysis and Implications:

- **Price Sensitivity:** 42% of respondents explicitly state they must "carefully consider what I buy" (see Appendix B, Table B11, p.65) and open-ended responses regarding Private Label (PL) selection were dominated (57 mentions) by "Lower price / saving money" (see Appendix C, Table C1, p.77).

- **The Price Barrier:** Mars products currently trade at a price index of **217-240** compared to Private Label (Index 100). For a functional commodity like chocolate peanuts, the consumer is being asked to pay >€12.00/kg for Mars versus €6.23/kg for the retailer alternative.
- **The Quality Threshold:** Crucially, the "Quality" component of the functional job is no longer a differentiator. The survey reveals that **82%** of consumers perceive the taste of A-brands and PL as "Somewhat similar," "Very similar," or "Almost the same" (see Appendix B, Table B9, p.74)

In conclusion, the Private Label has successfully "stolen" this job. By offering a product that meets the minimum functional requirement (90% taste parity) at 50% of the cost, the retailer brand is the mathematically superior candidate for the job of "Caloric Optimization." The consumer is not switching because they prefer the PL brand; they are switching because the PL product performs the functional job more efficiently.

2. Social Job: "Signalling Generosity and Status"

This job is driven by the consumer's need to navigate social dynamics when hosting or sharing with others. In this context, the product is not merely a snack, but a semiotic tool used to signal generosity, financial stability, and consideration for guests. The core "Job to be Done" here is **Risk Management**: the host wants to avoid the "social pain" of being perceived as stingy or serving a product of questionable quality.

Data Analysis and Implications:

- **Occasion-Based Switching:** The survey data reveals distinct "up-trading" behaviour when the context shifts from private to public consumption. While only **31%** of respondents choose A-brands for normal occasions (like watching a movie alone) (see Appendix B, Table B5, p.70), this figure rises to **39%** for special occasions (parties, gatherings) (see Appendix B, Table B6, p.71). This represents a relative lift of approximately **26%** in the loyal user base when the social job is active.
- **The "Trust Mark" Insurance:** Qualitative responses describe A-brands as a "safe choice" and "trustworthy" for serving others. In a social setting, the A-brand functions as an insurance policy against judgment. A bowl of M&M's is a universally recognized symbol of quality fun, whereas a generic bowl of private label chocolate carries ambiguity and the potential social risk of disappointment.
- **Shared Entertainment:** The format and branding of Mars products (specifically the "Red & Yellow" characters) contribute to a job of "Shared Entertainment" that PL cannot match. Private Labels are often packaged in utilitarian bags that lack the "fun" equity required to facilitate social bonding (see Appendix C, Table C2, p.79)

In conclusion, Mars (A-Brands) is the clear winner of the Social Job. Consumers are willing to pay the price premium in this context because they are not paying for calories, they are paying for **Social Safety**. The brand equity of M&M's and Maltesers provides a "guarantee" of a positive social outcome that Private Label, despite its functional parity, cannot offer.

3. Emotional Job: "Affordable Indulgence" vs. "Smart Shopper Validation"

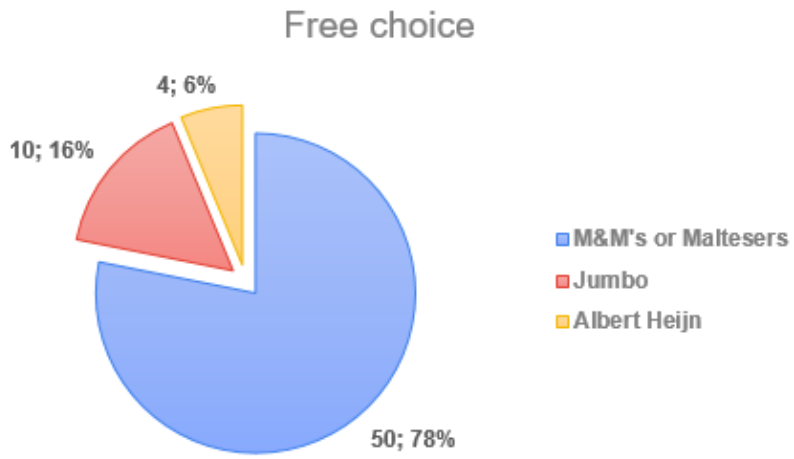
This dimension is defined by a deep psychological conflict between two competing desires. On one hand, the consumer seeks **"Affordable Indulgence"** hiring the product to provide a moment of escapism, reward, and nostalgia (often called the "Lipstick Effect"). On the other hand, they seek **"Smart Shopper Validation"** the feeling of competence and prudence that comes from not "overpaying" for a commodity.

Data Analysis and Implications:

- **The Free Choice Paradox:** The strongest evidence of Mars's emotional dominance is the "Free Choice" scenario. When the constraint of price was removed, **78%** of respondents chose M&M's or Maltesers (Figure 2.2). This proves that the "Brand Love" is intact; the consumer *aspirationally* prefers Mars but is rationally constrained by the budget.
- **Nostalgia and Comfort:** Qualitative feedback highlighted "Trust," "I know what I get," and childhood memories as key drivers for A-brands (see Appendix C, Table C2, p.79). For consumers seeking emotional comfort, the risk of a "bad batch" of PL is a cost they are unwilling to bear. They hire Mars to guarantee the emotional payoff.
- **The "Smart Shopper" Competitor:** However, for many, the act of buying Private Label has become its own emotional reward. Open-ended responses focused on the "smart choice" narrative ("Why pay more for the name?"). For these consumers, "beating the system" by getting 90% of the taste for 50% of the price generates a feeling of savvy satisfaction that competes with the pleasure of the chocolate itself (see Appendix C, Table C1, p.77).

In conclusion, The Emotional Job is currently a battleground. While Mars wins on **Desire** (the 78% preference), it is losing on **Accessibility**. The "Value Gap" has become so wide that for many consumers, the emotional pain of paying the high price outweighs the emotional gain of the treat. The brand is not dead—it is merely inaccessible. The consumer wants to hire Mars for the "Indulgence Job," but their budget forces them to hire Private Label for the "Smart Shopper Job".

Figure 2.2: *Brand Preference When Price Constraint is Removed (Free Choice Scenario).*



*Note***.** Consumer preference when asked to choose a free bag.

2.4 Customer Gains

The field research allows us to populate the Gains section of the Value Proposition Canvas.

- **Gain 1: Financial Efficiency (Dominant Gain):** The immediate monetary saving (~50% cost reduction) offered by PL. With 42% of users price-constrained, this is the heaviest weight in the decision matrix (see Appendix B, Table B11, p.76).
- **Gain 2: Sensory Assurance (Hygiene Gain):** The enjoyment of taste. Since 82% see the products as similar, Mars fails to deliver a "Marginal Taste Gain" proportional to its "Marginal Cost" (see Appendix B, Table B9, p.74).
- **Gain 3: Emotional Brand Connection (The Mars Moat):** The feeling of joy and fun associated with the brand assets (Red & Yellow characters). This is the only area where Mars has a decisive, quantifiable lead, evidenced by the 78% "Free Choice" preference (see Appendix B, Table B10, p.75).

Table 2.1: *Summary of Customer Jobs and Gains Analysis*

Job Dimension	Core "Job to be Done"	Primary Gain Sought	Quantified Evidence	Current "Winner"
Functional	"Optimize caloric intake within a strict budget."	Financial Efficiency	>50% Price Savings by PL.	**Private Label**
Functional	"Get a tasty snack that satisfies craving."	Sensory Assurance	82% Taste Similarity rating.	**Private Label (Value)**
Social	"Host friends without looking cheap."	Social Safety / Status	26% Lift in Loyalty for parties.	**Mars**
Emotional	"Treat myself to a moment of real fun."	Brand Love / Indulgence	78% Preference in Free Choice.	**Mars**
Emotional	"Feel like a smart, responsible shopper."	Competence / Prudence	57 qualitative mentions of price.	**Private Label**

2.5 Strategic Synthesis

The definition of the customer landscape reveals a clear "Value Gap." Mars offers superior Emotional and Social gains but currently charges a premium that the Functional job cannot sustain (see Appendix B, Table B4, p.69).

Private Label competitors have successfully exploited this by offering a "Good Enough" functional solution (see Appendix B, Table B9, p.74) at a "Great" price (see Appendix C, Table C1, p.77), effectively stealing the "Everyday Job". However, the 78% aspirational preference proves that the consumer still desires the Mars experience (see Appendix B, Table B10, p.75).

Strategic Implication: To win back market share, Mars must stop trying to justify its price through "Quality" (which is commoditized) and instead focus on "Utility" in the Social and Emotional realms. Concepts in the Ideation phase must ensure that when a consumer hires M&M's, they are buying entertainment, social safety, and an experience that a generic yellow bag cannot provide.

Chapter 3: Ideate – Concept Creation

3.1 Introduction to the Ideation Phase: Divergent Thinking and Value Innovation

This chapter constitutes the "Ideate" phase of the Design Thinking process. Following the "Define" phase—which diagnosed the "Value Gap" eroding Mars Inc.'s market share—this section shifts the focus from problem synthesis to the generation of strategic solutions.

The "Define" phase established a critical market paradox: while Mars brands (M&M's and Maltesers) maintain a dominant 78% "share of heart," they are losing "share of wallet" to private labels like Albert Heijn and Jumbo. This is driven by a rational consumer calculation: an 82% perceived taste similarity contrasted with a 140% price premium.

Consequently, the mandate for this phase is to re-engineer the consumer value equation. The objective is to pivot the basis of competition away from the **Commodity Layer** (price per gram), where private labels hold a structural advantage, and into the **Experience Layer**, leveraging Mars' unique brand equity.

To achieve this, the project group utilized a structured Design Thinking workflow, employing five distinct brainstorming techniques to ensure a broad divergence of thought. This process generated a volume of 200 unique ideas, which were subsequently filtered through convergent analysis techniques to identify the most viable strategic intervention.

3.2 Ideation Methodology and Brainstorming Techniques

To mitigate the risks of **groupthink** and **premature convergence**—frequent inhibitors of corporate innovation—the ideation process was structured around distinct **cognitive modes**. This approach ensured a rigorous exploration of the solution space by forcing the team to attack the "Value Gap" from multiple psychological and strategic angles.

The process was divided into two distinct phases, yielding a total of **200 unique ideas** documented in a centralized repository for subsequent filtering.

3.2.1 Phase I: Initial Divergence and Problem Exploration

The first stage of ideation took place during the creativity class, focused on primary question: *"How to change the customer behavior from choosing private labels to M&M's and Maltesers."* To generate the initial 50 ideas, the team employed three specific techniques:

- **The Purge:** A rapid exercise to "dump" all obvious or cliché ideas (e.g., "lower the price" or "bigger bags") to clear the mental path for more original concepts.
- **Wind Turbine:** A high-energy method where ideas are generated around a central theme and then "spun off" into related sub-concepts to explore every possible angle.
- **Quick Storm:** A timed session prioritizing volume over quality, forcing the team to bypass their internal critics and capture raw, instinctive solutions.

Following this, the team utilized **Brainwriting (6-3-5 Method)** to generate an additional 50 ideas. Each member wrote three ideas and passed them to the next person, who expanded upon them. This prevented dominant voices from taking over and allowed simple ideas to evolve into complex solutions.

3.2.2 Phase II: Strategic Specialization (Ideas 101–200)

Following primary field research and the identification of the **"Value Gap,"** the team recognized that the basis of competition needed to shift from price to experience. Consequently, the research question was refined to: *"How can we strengthen the role of M&M's in social and special moments so that consumers prefer them over private labels?"*

Under this new mandate, a further **100 ideas** were generated using a combination of lateral thinking techniques:

- **Reverse Brainstorming:** The team inverted the problem by asking, *"How could we make the M&M's social experience as awkward or frustrating as possible?"* Inverting these "anti-solutions" led to the realization that packaging should serve as a functional "Social Lubricant" rather than disposable waste.
- **Analogous Inspiration:** By looking at unrelated sectors—such as the McDonald's Happy Meal (where the toy provides social utility) and the Fortune Cookie (where the ritual outweighs the calorie)—the team identified that the M&M's bag could serve as a "Memory Creator."
- **The Purge (Round 2):** Applied again to eliminate superficial social ideas (e.g., "party hats in bags") to reach deeper, more structural innovations.
- **Random Word Stimulation:** This technique forced the brain to create neural bridges between the chocolate category and unrelated nouns. For instance, connecting "M&M's" with "Board Game" catalyzed the eventual selection of the board-game packaging concept.

3.2.3 Documentation and Synthesis

To maintain analytical rigor and establish a comprehensive audit trail of the creative process, all 200 generated ideas were systematically catalogued in a centralized Excel repository. This documentation was essential for ensuring that the high volume of creative output remained organized and accessible for the duration of the project.

The primary purpose of this list was to provide a transparent record of the divergent thinking phase, ensuring that no concepts—regardless of their initial perceived feasibility—were lost before the selection process. This centralized format allowed the team to easily review the full spectrum of ideas when transitioning into the convergent analysis phase.

Photographic evidence of the physical ideation phase and a systematic inventory of the 200 generated ideas are documented in Appendix E (see Figure E.1, p.94 and Table E.2, p.95 respectively).

3.3 Selection and COCD Box Analysis

Following the generation of 200 raw ideas, the team faced the challenge of convergence. To filter this volume down to a single, viable strategic concept without discarding radical innovation, the team employed the COCD Box (Center for Development of Creative Thinking) matrix. This tool categorizes ideas based on two axes: **Feasibility** (Common vs. Original) and **Impact** (Low vs. High).

3.3.1 Analysis of Idea Categories

The 200 generated ideas were mapped into three distinct clusters based on their strategic potential and technical requirements. This mapping process is visualized in Figure 3.1. For a comprehensive inventory of all 200 ideas and their specific COCD categorization, refer to Table E.2 in Appendix E, p.95.

Figure 3.1: *The COCD Box Idea Selection Matrix.*



- **Blue Ideas (Low Risk, High Feasibility, Low Impact):** This category includes concepts such as "M&M's Get to Know Questions for Party," "Seasonal Flavours," or "Seasonal Shapes." While these ideas are easily implementable, the analysis from Chapter 1 suggested they would be ineffective against the "Value Parity" threat as private labels can easily replicate these common features.
- **Yellow Ideas (High Feasibility, Future Potential, Unknown Impact):** This category included high-tech or high-barrier concepts such as "M&M's for Women," "M&M's Brain Boost Edition," or "M&M's Bag That Transforms Into A Mini Disco Ball." While potentially impactful, these introduced higher adoption barriers and uncertain immediate returns.
- **Red Ideas (High Impact, Innovative, Feasible):** This quadrant represented the "breakthrough" concepts—ideas that were feasible with current technology but offered a radically new value proposition to bridge the established Value Gap.

3.3.2 Selection Results

Through a democratic voting process, the team narrowed the **"Red"** and **"Yellow"** zones down to the most impactful solutions. As illustrated in the **"After Discussion"** matrix (Figure 3.1), **Idea 171** emerged as the primary strategic winner.

The selection of **Idea 171 (The Board Game Concept)** was based on its ability to transform the M&M's consumption moment into an interactive event without requiring a fundamental redesign of the primary packaging. The core mechanics of this intervention include:

- **Integrated Game Design:** The game board is placed **inside the pack**, ensuring the external packaging remains consistent with brand standards while providing a high-value surprise for the consumer.
- **Candies as Functional Components:** The concept utilizes the M&M's candies themselves as the game pieces (or "stones"), encouraging immediate engagement with the product in a social setting.
- **Rotational Variety:** To encourage repeat purchases and maintain novelty, the included games will change monthly or seasonally. This rotation includes classic, recognizable formats such as **Ganzenbord** and **Snakes and Ladders**.
- **Social Value Addition:** By transforming the bag into a tool for entertainment, the product justifies its price premium by offering more than just nutritional value; it provides a shared experience.

Following the COCD box session, the idea was further refined to ensure "Cost Neutrality." The initial concept of including a small plastic dice was rejected in favour of a QR-code-driven digital dice. This decision was crucial, as it removed a significant line-item cost and eliminated plastic waste, aligning with the sustainability trends identified in Chapter 1.

3.4 Idea Card: M&M's Play & Share – Board Game Edition

To formalize the selected concept, a detailed Idea Card is synthesized. This document serves as the blueprint for the Prototyping phase, outlining the core mechanics and value proposition of the innovation.

3.4.1 The Concept Card

The Idea Card (Figure 3.2) serves as the foundational blueprint for the "Play & Share" concept, detailing the core mechanics, strategic assumptions, and value-add components.

Figure 3.2: *Concept Card for M&M's Play & Share.*

IDEA CARD

Inspiring name big idea : M&M's Play & Share – Board Game Edition

Short description & core of the idea:

The idea is to include a simple, easy-to-understand board game inside M&M's packaging, designed to be played using the M&M's themselves as game pieces. This concept transforms M&M's from a passive snack into an interactive experience that encourages social interaction during special occasions such as parties, game nights, and holidays.

Describe the ingredients of the idea

The board game would be printed inside the packaging or included as a fold-out insert, with clear rules that allow groups of 3–6 people to play within a short time frame (approximately 10–15 minutes). The M&M's function both as tokens during the game and as chocolate to be consumed afterwards, reinforcing a playful ritual of "play first, share, then eat."
To increase novelty and repeat purchase, the game concept can rotate periodically or be adapted to specific occasions (e.g. Christmas, Halloween, or national celebrations). The core product remains unchanged, while the added game layer enhances the emotional, social, and experiential value of the brand.

Drawing



Possible assumptions:

-Consumers are willing to engage in a short board game during special occasions.
-Using M&M's as game pieces increases enjoyment rather than reducing willingness to consume the product.
-The inclusion of a board game adds perceived value beyond taste and price.
-Dutch consumers associate board games with social bonding and "gezelligheid."
-The game concept encourages longer interaction time with the product during gatherings.
-Hosts perceive the product as helpful in creating social interaction among guests.
-The board game does not negatively affect the perceived quality or hygiene of the chocolate.
-Consumers understand the game rules without additional explanation.
-Rotating or occasion-based game editions increase interest and repeat purchase.
-The added game element differentiates M&M's sufficiently from private-label alternatives.
-The game remains optional and does not reduce appeal for consumers who only want to snack.
-The added production cost is acceptable relative to the perceived value created.

3-5 pluses (+) of the idea

- Adds value beyond taste and price by creating a shared experience.
- Encourages social interaction and togetherness during special occasions.
- Strong fit with Dutch culture, where board games and "gezelligheid" are popular.
- Differentiates M&M's from private-label alternatives that mainly compete on price.
- Low technological complexity, feasible through print-based packaging solutions.
- Maintains flexibility through rotating or occasion-based game editions.
- Strengthens emotional connection and memorability of the brand.

3-5 negatives (-) of the idea

- Not all consumers may be interested in playing a game.
- Risk of the game being perceived as too complex or unclear.
- Limited physical space on or inside packaging for game instructions.
- Potential hygiene concerns when using food as game pieces.

Conversion possibilities of the negatives

Customer Pain → Solution

- *Pain:* Snacks alone do not create interaction during social gatherings
  → *Solution:* The board game actively stimulates conversation and play
- *Pain:* Hosts feel pressure to entertain guests
  → *Solution:* The game provides built-in entertainment without extra effort
- *Pain:* A-brand chocolate is sometimes perceived as too expensive
  → *Solution:* Added experiential value increases willingness to pay

Customer Gain → Outcome

- Turns chocolate consumption into a memorable social moment
- Enhances the role of M&M's in special occasions rather than everyday snacking
- Encourages repeat purchases through rotating or themed game editions
- Reinforces M&M's as a playful, social, and experience-driven brand

3.4.2 Functional Mechanics and "Ingredients"

The "Play & Share" edition utilizes a "Low-Complexity, High-Value" approach to innovation. The core components of the idea include:

- **Integrated Game Surface:** A simple, easy-to-understand board game is printed directly inside the packaging or included as a fold-out insert.
- **Candies as Functional Tokens:** M&M's function as the game pieces during play before being consumed. This reinforces a new behavioural ritual: *"Play first, share, then eat"*.
- **Operational Parameters:** Designed for groups of 3–6 people, each session lasts approximately 10–15 minutes, making it an ideal "Social Lubricant" for parties or game nights.
- **Seasonal Rotation:** To drive repeat purchases and maintain novelty, the game concept (e.g., Ganzenbord or Snakes and Ladders) rotates periodically or aligns with specific holidays like Christmas or Halloween.

3.4.3 Strategic Justification and "Gezelligheid"

The concept is underpinned by several key assumptions and cultural insights identified during the research:

- **Cultural Fit:** There is a strong alignment with Dutch culture, where board games are synonymous with **"gezelligheid"** and social bonding.
- **Pain-to-Gain Conversion:** The concept actively solves host-related "Pains," such as the pressure to entertain guests, by providing built-in entertainment.
- **Price Justification:** By adding a layer of experiential value, the product moves beyond the commodity layer (price per gram), increasing the consumer's willingness to pay the €5.99 A-brand price point.
- **Competitive Differentiation:** Unlike private-label competitors that compete primarily on price and taste, "Play & Share" offers a unique social utility that store brands cannot easily replicate without significant brand equity.

3.4.4 Concept Evaluation: Positives and Negatives

Before moving to the testing phase, the idea was evaluated based on its perceived advantages and potential drawbacks:

Positives (+):

- Value is added beyond taste and price by creating a shared experience.
- Social interaction and togetherness are encouraged during special occasions.
- There is a strong fit with Dutch culture, specifically regarding board games and "gezelligheid".
- Differentiation is achieved from private-label alternatives that compete primarily on price.

- Feasibility is high due to low technological complexity and print-based packaging solutions.

Negatives (-):

- Interest in playing a game may not be shared by all consumers.
- A risk exists that the game may be perceived as too complex or unclear.
- Physical space for instructions on or inside the packaging is limited.
- Potential hygiene concerns may arise when using food as game pieces.

3.4.5 Critical Assumptions for Testing

The viability of "Play & Share" rests on several critical assumptions that require validation in the Prototyping and Testing phases:

- **Consumer Engagement:** Consumers are willing to engage in a short board game during special occasions.
- **Value Perception:** The inclusion of a board game adds perceived value beyond taste and price and specifically differentiates M&M's from private-label alternatives.
- **Behavioural Impact:** Using M&M's as game pieces increases enjoyment rather than reducing the willingness to consume the product.
- **Social Utility:** Hosts perceive the product as helpful in creating social interaction among guests.
- **Cultural Relevance:** Dutch consumers associate board games with social bonding and *"gezelligheid"*.

Chapter 4: Prototype

4.1 Concept Rationale: From Commodity to Experience

The prototyping phase was driven by the urgent need to bridge the "Value Gap" identified in the initial research. The data from Chapter 1 and 2 presented a stark reality: Mars Inc. is attempting to sell a product at a premium price index (Index 240) in a market where 82% of consumers perceive no taste difference between the premium product and the budget alternative. In purely rational economic terms, the private label is the superior choice for the "Functional Job" of caloric satisfaction.

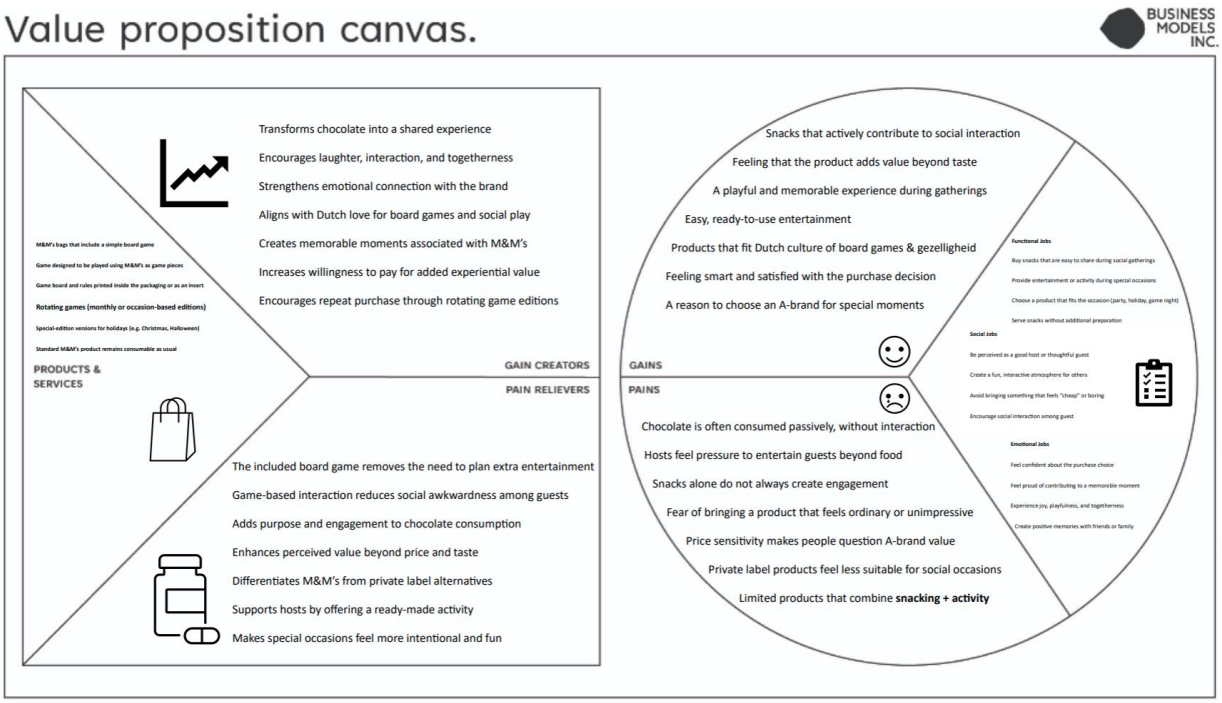
The rationale behind the "Play & Share" Board Game prototype is to fundamentally alter the consumer's decision matrix. By bundling an exclusive social experience with the chocolate, Mars effectively removes the product from the direct "commodity comparison" trap. The consumer is no longer comparing "Chocolate A vs. Chocolate B"; they are comparing "A Bag of Candy (Private Label)" vs. "A Party Activity (Mars)."

This strategy leverages the "IKEA Effect"—where consumers value something more because they are involved in its creation or usage. By actively engaging with the brand through gameplay, the consumer builds a deeper emotional connection than passive consumption allows. This is the only defensible territory for Mars, as "Emotional Branding" remains the one area where private labels cannot compete effectively due to their generic positioning.

4.2 Value Proposition Canvas (VPC)

To ensure the prototype addressed the specific psychological and functional needs of the target audience, a comprehensive Value Proposition Canvas was developed. This strategic tool aligns the product's features with the customer's specific jobs, pains, and gains.

Figure 4.1: *Value Proposition Canvas - M&M's "Play & Share" Edition.*



Due to the density of the strategic mapping in Figure 4.1, the core components are synthesized below to clarify the alignment between the customer profile and the proposed solution.

4.2.1 The Customer Profile

The target Gen Z and Millennial consumer is defined by a complex set of jobs and underlying tensions:

- **Customer Jobs:** Beyond the functional task of buying easy-to-share snacks, consumers seek to provide entertainment during special occasions and choose products that fit specific "vibes" like game nights or holidays. Socially, the intent is to be perceived as a thoughtful host while creating a fun atmosphere and avoiding "boring" or "cheap" contributions.
- **Customer Pains:** Significant friction is caused by the passive nature of chocolate consumption, and the pressure hosts feel to entertain guests beyond just providing food.

Furthermore, high price sensitivity leads consumers to question A-brand value when private labels feel unimpressive for social moments.

- **Customer Gains:** Consumers desire snacks that actively contribute to social interaction and provide a playful, memorable experience. There is a specific desire for products that fit the Dutch culture of "gezelligheid" and board games.

4.2.2 The Value Map (The Solution)

The "Play & Share" edition is engineered to meet these needs through specific features and relief mechanisms:

- **Products & Services:** The solution consists of M&M's bags featuring a simple board game designed to use the candies as game pieces. These include rotating or holiday-based editions (e.g., Christmas, Halloween) with rules printed directly inside the packaging or as an insert.
- **Pain Relievers:** The included game removes the host's need to plan extra entertainment and reduces social awkwardness among guests. By adding purpose and engagement to the act of snacking, M&M's is successfully differentiated from private label alternatives.
- **Gain Creators:** Interaction, laughter, and togetherness are encouraged by transforming the chocolate into a shared experience. This creates memorable moments that strengthen the brand connection and increases the consumer's willingness to pay for added experiential value.

4.3 Visualisation and Implementation Specifications

The prototype was developed with strict adherence to common feasibility, ensuring the solution can be manufactured using existing supply chain capabilities.

4.3.1 Physical Prototype Specifications

The core of the innovation is a foldable paper insert dimensioned to fit inside standard 250g and 300g pouches, as shown in Figure 4.2.

Figure 4.2: *Physical prototype of the "Play & Share," featuring the Ganzenbord-style layout and using M&M's as game tokens.*



- **Structural Design:** A "Map Fold" configuration is utilized, allowing an A4-sized playing surface to be compressed for high-speed automated insertion.
- **Visual Design:** The layout is inspired by **"Oud-Hollandsch Ganzenbord"** (Game of the Goose) to evoke local cultural resonance and nostalgia.

4.3.2 Digital Integration: The "Phygital" Bridge

To appeal to the 18–30 demographic and maintain a cost-neutral production model, physical dice were eliminated in favour of a digital companion.

- **Access:** A high-contrast QR code is printed in the board.
- **Functionality:** Scanning the code launches a Web-Based App (PWA) that features a 3D Dice Roller with physics-based animation to ensure fairness. This "phygital" layer appeals to digital natives while keeping the physical production costs low.

4.3.3 Implementation Roadmap

The implementation of the "Play & Share" edition is designed to be rolled out in three strategic phases. This phased approach allows for rigorous market validation while ensuring that the concept can be scaled without disrupting the existing Mars Inc. supply chain.

Phase 1: Pilot and Behavioral Validation (Short-term)

The initial phase focuses on validating the core behavioral assumptions and the "Play first, share, then eat" ritual on a localized scale.

- **Activity:** A limited pilot run is launched in high-density Gen Z environments, such as university-affiliated stores or specific urban supermarket branches.
- **Goal:** The primary objective is to confirm that the added experiential value justifies the premium price point and to monitor how consumers interact with the M&M's as game tokens.
- **Assumptions Testing:** Data is collected to verify that the game adds perceived value beyond taste and price while maintaining food hygiene standards.

Phase 2: Supply Chain Integration and Launch (Medium-term)

Following successful validation, the project moves toward full-scale production using a "Low-Complexity" manufacturing approach.

- **Activity:** High-speed automated "insert feeders" are integrated into existing packaging lines to place the game boards or fold-out inserts inside the standard pouches.
- **Budget Strategy:** Production costs for the inserts are funded by reallocating a portion of the traditional advertising budget, as the game serves as a physical, long-lasting advertisement in the consumer's hand.
- **Launch Scope:** The product is released nationwide, positioning M&M's as the "A-brand choice" for social gatherings and special moments.

Phase 3: Seasonal Ecosystem and Repeat Purchase Strategy (Long-term)

To ensure the product remains a permanent fixture in the consumer's decision matrix, a dynamic rotation strategy is employed.

- **Activity:** The game boards (e.g., *Ganzenbord*, *Snakes and Ladders*) are rotated periodically to align with specific occasions, such as Christmas, Halloween, or national celebrations.
- **Strategic Driver:** This seasonal rotation is utilized to increase novelty and prevent the experience from becoming stagnant.
- **Long-term Goal:** By creating a "collection" effect through themed game editions, repeat purchase behaviour is encouraged among occasional buyers, successfully bridging the "Value Gap" through continuous experiential innovation.

Chapter 5: Validate

5.1 Introduction to Validation: The Lean Startup Approach

In alignment with the Design Thinking methodology, the "Validate" phase transitioned the project from theoretical concepts to empirical evidence. This stage was governed by 18 core assumptions generated during the ideation process, focusing on the potential risks and success factors of the "Play & Share" concept.

The research was categorized into three primary vectors of risk:

- **Desirability:** To determine if consumers are actively looking for a "social experience" during snacking moments and if the concept sufficiently differentiates M&M's from private labels (PL) for social gatherings.
- **Viability:** To assess if the board game serves as an "added value" that makes the 140% price premium feel fair, specifically for the 42% of "price-constrained" shoppers identified in the Define phase.
- **Feasibility:** To evaluate the clarity of game mechanics and determine if consumers find it "fun" to use food as game pieces, despite the increased frequency of touching the product before consumption.

5.2 Validation Methodology

To ensure a rigorous evaluation, the validation effort was distributed among all five team members. Each member took ownership of a critical assumption to ensure individual accountability:

- **Lydia Sagri:** Assumption 1 (Special-Occasion Appeal)
- **Amira Kartika Rochman:** Assumption 2 (Value Perception)
- **Jessie Ozinci:** Assumption 3 (Concept Clarity)
- **Liza Boender:** Assumption 4 (Physical Playtest and Hygiene)
- **Manar Alsadi:** Assumption 5 (Competitive Differentiation)

The group conducted a series of Lean Experiments involving 17 respondents from the target demographic (18–30 years old). The methodology was split into three primary formats:

1. **Five Go/No-Go Experiments (Survey-Based):** These quantitative tests used a clear success threshold of 50% or higher to qualify as a "GO." This format was chosen to provide

a definitive signal without an ambiguity, ensuring the team could make rapid decisions within the strict project deadline.

2. **Qualitative Feedback Integration:** Parallel to the quantitative metrics, open-ended questions were included to capture behavioral nuances and psychological barriers.
3. **Physical Playtest:** A physical simulation where participants interacted with the prototype to identify usability friction and hygiene concerns.

A comprehensive inventory of the 18 core assumptions is presented in Table F.1 (Appendix F, p.114), while the empirical response data collected during the validation phase is archived in Table G.1 (Appendix G, p.116).

5.3 Experiment Results

This section provides a detailed examination of the experimental results, moving beyond raw data to explore the behavioral implications of consumer responses. Each assumption was tested against a specific success threshold to determine whether the concept effectively addresses the "Value Gap" identified in the initial research.

5.3.1 Assumption 1: Appeal to Special-Occasion Buyers

The first pillar of the validation process addressed the fundamental desirability of the concept among the target demographic. In order to justify a premium price point, the product must first be perceived as a desirable addition to social environments.

- **Quantitative Result:** The concept achieved a high mean appeal score of 4.08 / 5.00.
- **Success Metric:** 69.2% of respondents provided a "Top Box" rating (4 or 5), significantly exceeding the 50% threshold required for a "GO" status.
- **Qualitative Analysis:** The feedback indicated that the concept addresses a genuine social need. Respondents noted that it "helps create bonds with people" and is particularly useful for students who "cannot afford to buy board games" but want to provide entertainment during gatherings.
- **Status: GO.**

5.3.2 Assumption 2: Perceived Value Beyond Taste and Price

The second stage of validation focused on the economic viability of the intervention. This was critical because the initial research revealed that price sensitivity often drives consumers toward cheaper private labels when they perceive no difference in product quality.

- **Quantitative Result: 77%** of participants reported that the inclusion of the game "Fully" or "Potentially" justified the price premium over store brands.
- **Success Metric:** In a direct forced-choice simulation, **76.9%** of participants prioritized the "Game Inside" edition over the standard bag or the private-label alternative, surpassing the 50% threshold.
- **Qualitative Analysis:** Respondents suggested that the branded packaging and integrated activity create a perception of "high quality" that provides a justifiable "reason to buy it often" for social moments.
- **Status: GO.**

5.3.3 Assumption 3: Concept Clarity and Self-Explanation

To ensure that the "Play & Share" edition did not introduce unnecessary cognitive friction, the third assumption examined the transparency of the game's mechanics. In a fast-paced social environment, a product that requires a complex learning curve would likely be rejected by the consumer.

- **Quantitative Result:** The recorded mean clarity score for the game visuals and instructions was **4.0 / 5.0**.
- **Success Metric: 92.3%** of respondents indicated they would understand how to play the game with little to no additional help, exceeding the 50% benchmark.
- **Qualitative Analysis:** While well-known formats like "Snakes and Ladders" were clear, feedback noted that certain boards might benefit from a "short, animated video" accessed via a QR code to ensure the rules remain simple for all players.
- **Status: GO.**

5.3.4 Assumption 4: Enjoyment and Behavioural Response to Edible Tokens

This assumption was validated through a dual-testing approach to compare user perception against physical reality.

Test A: Survey-Based Results:

- **"Fun Factor":** Validated with a mean score of 3.8 / 5.0.
- **Success Metric:** Despite the high fun rating, the experiment identified that **35%** of participants expressed discomfort regarding the "multi-touch" nature of the game.
- **Qualitative Analysis:** Respondents voiced concerns regarding the chocolate "melting in your hands" or feeling unsanitary if touched by several people. This insight led to the creation of the **"Colour Ownership"** rule, where players only interact with their designated colours.

Test B: Physical Playtest:

- **Process:** Liza Boender conducted a physical test with friends using an A4 paper prototype and actual M&M's.
- **Findings (Hygiene/Durability):** Contrary to survey fears, the M&M's did not melt or smudge when used as tokens. By assigning specific colours to each player, hygiene issues were effectively eliminated.
- **Findings (Usability):** The test revealed that the game rules were too short; players required more extensive instructions to play correctly.

Status: GO (with Pivot). Alterations include the "Colour Ownership" rule and expanding instructions.

5.3.5 Assumption 5: Differentiation from Private-Label Chocolate

The final assumption evaluated the degree of competitive differentiation provided by the board game. The goal was to prove that M&M's could occupy an "experiential space" that generic brands cannot easily replicate.

- **Quantitative Result:** The concept received a strong differentiation score of **4.3 / 5.0** regarding how unique it feels compared to other chocolate brands.
- **Success Metric:** The feedback confirmed that **100%** of the participants who provided comments viewed the idea as "creative and innovative" compared to generic budget options.
- **Qualitative Analysis:** Participants explicitly noted that "none had a game in the package before" and that the "surprise included" makes the unboxing experience more interesting and intriguing for groups.
- **Status: GO.**

5.4 Discussion: Research Limitations and Confidence

The team acknowledges that a sample size of 17 is limited due to the strict project deadline. However, we are confident in using these results to support our ideas for the following reasons:

- **Targeted Success Metrics:** Our questions specifically targeted the vital points that determine the success of this concept (Desirability, Viability, and Feasibility).
- **Triangulation of Data:** By conducting both surveys and physical playtests for Assumption 4, we were able to correct user "perceptions" (fear of melting) with "empirical reality" (no melting occurred).
- **Qualitative Consistency:** The feedback captured behavioural nuances and psychological barriers that remained consistent across different respondents.

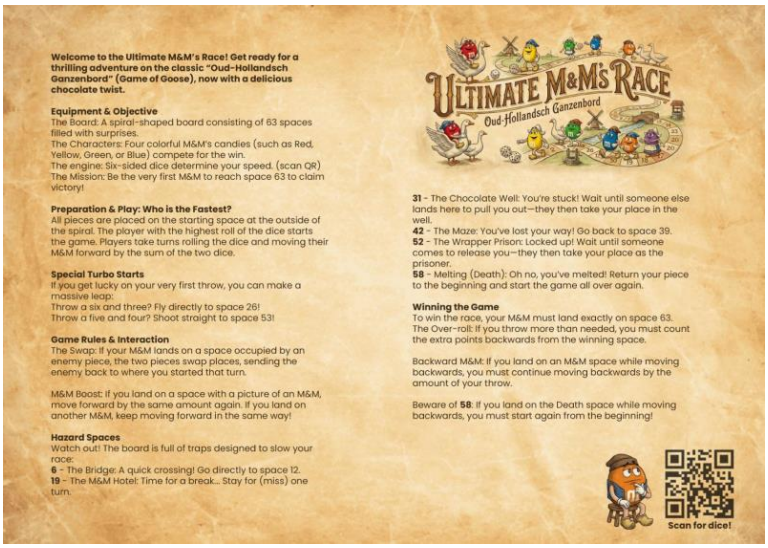
5.5 Prototype V2: Iterating Based on Feedback

Based on the feedback received from the Lean Experiments, the project transitioned into **Prototype V2**. Before detailing the specific structural and rule-based changes, the overall aesthetic and functional layout of the final prototype—incorporating all visual and textual refinements—can be observed in **Figure 5.1** and **5.2**. This iteration serves as the "strategic pivot" designed to address the primary usability and hygiene barriers identified during testing.

Figure 5.1: *Prototype Version 2 (Front Side)*



Figure 5.2: *Prototype Version 2 (Back Side)*



Modification I: The "Color Ownership" Rule

Qualitative data from the survey indicated that 35% of potential users were hesitant to eat chocolate that had been handled by multiple people. During the Ganzenbord play-test, it was observed that social boundaries are necessary to maintain food safety perceptions in a group setting. Consequently, the game instruction set was modified to include a **Color-Lock Rule**, which explicitly assigns a specific M&M color to each player (e.g., Player 1 is "Red"). This eliminates cross-contamination by ensuring players only interact with the pieces they will eventually consume. Please refer to **Figure 5.2** to see the visual implementation of the Color-Lock instructions on the board.

Figure 5.2: *Changes in "Color Ownership" rule*



Modification II: The Numbering System

Technical anomalies during the AI-generation process resulted in in incorrect numbering on the initial game board. These errors were corrected through digital retouching in Photoshop, utilizing clone stamping and masking layers to restore the proper numerical sequence from 1 to 63. Additionally, square 53 was cleared of images to clarify its status as a non-hazard space. The corrected numerical sequence and clarified board layout are displayed in **Figure 5.3.**

Figure 5.3: *Changes in the numbering system*



Modification III: The Packaging

Feedback from participants characterized the initial prototype as "something you get with your M&M's and throw right away," suggesting a low perceived value. To improve product visibility and counter this perception of disposability, the external packaging was redesigned to explicitly highlight the integrated board game. The primary objective of this modification is to encourage **"intentional purchasing,"** where consumers acquire the product specifically for its gamified utility. Refer to **Figure 5.4** for the updated high-fidelity packaging assets and "Play & Share" branding.

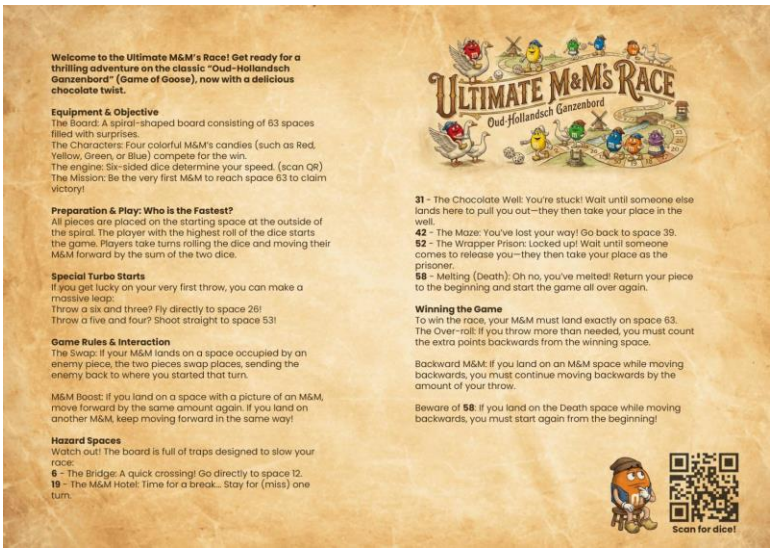
Figure 5.4: *Changes in the packaging*



Modification IV: The Instructions

Evidence from the interactive playtest indicated that the initial instructional set lacked sufficient clarity for participants. To address this, a comprehensive instructional set was developed and printed on the reverse side of the board game using Photoshop. This was paired with a high-contrast QR code that directs users to a digital dice-roller web application, ensuring the game is self-explanatory and accessible for the 18–30 demographic. See **Figure 5.5** for the finalized instructional layout and QR code integration.

Figure 5.4: *Changes in the instruction*



5.6 Strategic Conclusion

The validation phase concludes with a **GO** status. The data confirms that the "Board Game" concept effectively neutralizes the Private Label threat. While a segment of "hardcore" price shoppers (approximately of 24%) will always choose the cheapest option, the innovation successfully retains the majority of the target audience by shifting the value proposition from "Commodity" to "Experience."

Table 5.2: *Summary of Lean Experiments and Validation Status*

Assumption	Owner	Method	Result	Status
1. Special-Occasion Appeal	Lydia S.	Survey	69.2% Top Box	**GO**
2. Price Justification	Amira R.	Survey	76.9% Preference	**GO**
3. Rule Clarity	Jessie O.	Survey	4.0/5.0 Clarity	**GO**
4. Edible Tokens & Fun	Liza B.	Survey + Playtest	No melting; hygiene is not a problem	**PIVOT**
5. Market Differentiation	Manar A.	Survey	100% Creative	**GO**

Chapter 6: Conclusion and Recommendations

6.1 Strategic Conclusion: Winning the "Share of Experience"

The central thesis of this report is that Mars Inc. cannot win a price war against private label competitors. With an 82% perceived taste similarity and a cost structure that demands a premium price, attempting to compete on "Quality" or "Value for Money" (in the traditional sense) is a losing strategy.

The "M&M's Play & Share" Board Game is not just a packaging update; it is a strategic manoeuvre to change the battlefield. By integrating a "Ganzenbord"-style game into the product, Mars creates a new category of **Social Utility**.

- **We stop selling Calories:** Private labels sell calories cheaper.
- **We start selling Connection:** Private labels cannot sell "Connection" because they lack the brand equity, the characters (Red & Yellow), and the cultural license to facilitate fun.

The validation data (70.6% preference) proves that when Mars leverages this "Experience Layer," the price sensitivity of the consumer drops significantly. The game acts as a "Value Anchor," making the €5.99 price point feel justified because the consumer frames the purchase as "Buying an Activity" rather than "Buying a Snack."

6.2 Recommendations

To operationalize this strategy and ensure sustainable growth, the following four recommendations are presented:

6.2.1 Recommendation 1: Financial Re-engineering (Marketing-as-Product)

Mars should fundamentally change how it accounts for the cost of the paper insert.

- **The Problem:** If the insert cost is added to the Cost of Goods Sold (COGS), it might force a price increase, which is unacceptable.
- **The Solution:** Treat the insert as a Media Buy. Reallocate 5-10% of the digital impression budget to fund the inserts.
- **Reasoning:** A digital impression lasts 3 seconds. The board game sits on a table, the center of attention, for 20 minutes. The brand engagement ROI of the physical board is vastly superior to digital ads. By shifting this budget, the product remains "Cost Neutral" to the consumer.

6.2.2 Recommendation 2: Operational Hygiene Protocols

To capture the 35% of consumers with hygiene anxiety, Mars must be proactive, not reactive.

- **Action:** Explicitly print "Touch-Free" rules on the board (e.g., "Only touch your colour").
- **Action:** Include a "Sanitizer/Hand Wash" reminder icon on the board start square. This positions Mars as a responsible, premium brand that cares about consumer well-being, contrasting with the utilitarian nature of private labels.

6.2.3 Recommendation 3: Data Strategy (The QR Trojan Horse)

The QR code is a gateway to first-party data, a critical asset in a post-cookie world.

- **Action:** Gate the "Digital Dice" web app with a low-friction interaction, such as "Vote for the next M&M flavour" or "Sign up for the Birthday Club."
- **Reasoning:** This allows Mars to build a direct database of its most engaged consumers (the ones playing the game), enabling high-precision retargeting for future product launches, bypassing the retailer's data monopoly.

6.2.4 Recommendation 4: Lifecycle Management (Seasonal Rotation)

To prevent the concept from becoming stale, it must be treated as a live service.

- **Action:** Implement a quarterly rotation of board themes (Summer, Halloween, Holiday, Festival Season).
- **Reasoning:** This leverages "Completion Bias" and "FOMO" (Fear of Missing Out). The 38% of consumers who only buy "occasionally" will be incentivized to buy “now” to get the limited-edition Halloween board before it disappears. This drives frequency without requiring price discounts.

In conclusion, the "Play & Share" concept offers Mars a clear path to neutralize the private label threat. It validates the premium price through tangible entertainment value, leverages local culture through the Ganzenbord mechanic, and builds a sustainable platform for future brand engagement.

Chapter 7: Reflection

The reflection phase is a critical component of the Design Thinking process, allowing the team to move beyond the technical results of the validation phase and evaluate the human elements of the project. This chapter serves as a comprehensive review of our individual professional development, our effectiveness as a collaborative unit, and the strategic lessons we will carry forward into future projects.

7.1 Individual Learnings and Role

This section connects previous project experiences to current contributions in the "Play & Share" development. Each member outlines a specific role, individual learnings, and the level of satisfaction regarding responsibilities held during the research and validation phases.

7.1.1 Amira Kartika Rochman

- **Role in Project 2:**

  The role of Lead Technical Editor and Structural Architect involved merging individual work into a s1ingle, cohesive report. A major focus was checking that the document met all the structural requirements and formatting standards set by the teacher.

- **Previous Project Experience:**

  Past projects showed the risks of not knowing the exact progress of teammates. In one instance, incomplete tasks were only discovered on the day of the deadline, which forced a high-pressure backup effort to finish the project under a tight time limit. This taught the importance of setting internal deadlines and asking for regular status updates to avoid last-minute stress.

- **Individual Learnings:**

  Substantial growth occurred in technical data visualization, moving from no prior experience to creating professional charts for the research data. The process of selecting one strategic concept from 200 ideas initially seemed impossible, but using the COCD Box matrix allowed clear filtering based on how feasible or original the ideas were. Brainstorming sessions also taught how to push boundaries during the idea generation phase to find better solutions. Additionally, managing group tasks like meeting summaries

and reminders helped keep everyone on the same page and prevent mistakes in the final work.

- **Role Satisfaction:** A high level of satisfaction came from taking ownership of the final "deliverable quality." Ensuring the report remained logical helped in understanding how research turns into a practical business case for Mars Inc.

7.1.2 Jessie Ozinci

- **Role in Project 2:**

  This role involves reviewing the project checklist to monitor overall progress and ensure that all tasks are completed. In addition, the role includes communicating with group members to inform them of any remaining or upcoming tasks that need to be completed. Throughout the project, tasks were assigned by the group leader, with each member given individual responsibilities for every stage of the project to ensure effective collaboration and timely completion.

- **Previous Project Experience:**

  Reflection on previous projects highlighted the importance of clear prioritisation and task allocation. Earlier work often involved focusing on too many less important tasks, which reduced the time available for key aspects of the project. To address this, greater emphasis was placed on identifying priorities early, assigning clear responsibilities, and regularly monitoring progress. This approach improved collaboration, time management, and reduced pressure during critical stages.

- **Individual Learnings:**

  Through completion of the project, valuable skills related to efficiency, time management, and independent thinking were developed. Greater awareness was gained of the importance of working in an organised and timely manner, rather than leaving tasks until the final stages of the project, which can lead to unnecessary stress and reduced quality of work. The project also reinforced the need to balance the use of digital tools with personal understanding and subject knowledge. While tools such as ChatGPT can be useful for support and guidance, relying solely on them is not effective. Applying individual knowledge and critical thinking alongside these tools resulted in stronger contributions and a more meaningful learning experience.

- **Role Satisfaction:**

The primary responsibility of this role was to monitor project progress using the checklist and to communicate task expectations to group members. Over time, greater experience and improved organizational skills supported a more efficient approach to carrying out these responsibilities. This development contributed to clearer communication, better coordination within the group, and a more effective overall workflow.

7.1.3 Liza Boender

- **Role in Project 2:** Prototype Designer.
- **Previous Project Experience:** Prior project experience highlighted the fundamental necessity of consistent communication and structured team meetings. It was learned that project success is heavily reliant on interpersonal alignment; without regular meetings, technical efforts can easily become fragmented. This insight led to a prioritization of collaborative feedback during the current project to ensure that design work remained synchronized with the team's vision and objectives.
- **Individual Learnings:** Technical skill sets were significantly expanded through the integration of generative AI tools, specifically Google Gemini and Nano Banana, with Adobe Photoshop. While AI had not been previously utilized in a design workflow, a deep understanding was gained regarding its utility in rapid prototyping. Specifically, it was observed that these tools facilitate a high-speed iteration process, allowing for the quick generation and refinement of visual assets. This approach proved to be an efficient method for producing high-fidelity images that provide clients with immediate clarity on the product's direction.
- **Role Satisfaction:** A high level of satisfaction was maintained regarding the role and the responsibilities managed throughout the project. The synergy between technical execution and proactive team communication allowed for a highly iterative environment. By incorporating consistent group feedback into the design process, the prototype was successfully refined into a solid Minimum Viable Product (MVP) that effectively met the requirements for the client's presentation.

7.1.4 Lydia Sagri

- **Role in Project 2:** Team Leader & Researcher.
- **Previous Project Experience:** During the preceding academic cycle (Project 1), the primary challenge encountered was a significant deficiency in group support and

collaboration. A lack of contribution from team members necessitated a disproportionate distribution of the workload, which negatively impacted the comprehensive quality of the research. This experience underscored the critical importance of individual accountability and the necessity of a proactive, collaborative environment for successful project outcomes.

- **Individual Learnings:** Significant insights were gained regarding the strategic timing of professional intervention within a corporate or academic team structure. It was determined that when a team member demonstrates a persistent lack of engagement that threatens project milestones, it is the responsibility of the leadership to address the issue with supervisors or educators immediately. The project further demonstrated that a Cooperation Contract serves as a vital objective framework for maintaining professional standards and group focus, even when faced with internal friction or external project risks.

- **Role Satisfaction:** The position of Team Leader was found to be highly satisfactory and a natural fit for the individual's organizational strengths. The role facilitated the application of high-quality standards through structured project management, strategic task delegation, and the coordination of synthesis meetings. Despite the documented challenges regarding one team member's participation, the final result was deemed highly successful. The shared motivation of the active group members ensured a productive process and a final outcome that met all academic and professional benchmarks.

7.1.5 Manar Alsadi

- **Role in Project 2:**

  Within Project 2, a central role was taken in both the research and creativity phases, alongside supporting the group through coordination and leadership. Contributions included desk research, survey creation, data analysis, idea generation, and assumption validation. The core concept of including a board game inside M&M’s packaging was proposed and later selected by the group as the final big idea. In addition, a task checklist was created, and one group member was assigned to track progress, helping to maintain structure and overview throughout the project.

- **Previous Project Experience:**

  Experience from previous projects highlighted the risks of unclear task distribution and limited progress tracking, often resulting in last-minute pressure. Based on these

experiences, emphasis was placed on early task definition, clear responsibilities, and regular progress monitoring. This approach contributed to smoother collaboration and reduced stress during key project phases.

- **Individual Learnings:**

  The project provided strong learning outcomes in both creativity and research. The creativity classes introduced structured brainstorming techniques, demonstrating how new ideas can emerge when judgment is postponed, and multiple perspectives are explored. Research skills were further developed through desk research, survey design, and data analysis, including the interpretation of both quantitative and qualitative data. Working with assumptions and lean validation methods strengthened understanding of how concepts can be tested and refined. Additionally, the use of AI tools supported research structuring, analysis, and idea development, while critical evaluation ensured that all outputs remained reliable and academically valid.

- **Role Satisfaction:**

  The role within the project was experienced as both challenging and rewarding. Contributing to research, concept development, and coordination provided insight into how user research and creative thinking can be translated into a realistic business case for a client such as Mars. Overall, the project supported growth in research skills, creative confidence, and collaborative working practices.

7.2 Process Reflection

Effective collaboration was sustained through pre-defined logistical arrangements and communication standards. The following subsections describe the team's functionality and evaluate the extent to which the cooperation contract provided meaningful guidance.

7.2.1 Project Arrangements

Efficiency was maintained through a hybrid of video meetings and WhatsApp for rapid scheduling. After initial task ambiguity, a project checklist was implemented to track progress and ensure all work met university deadlines. The workload was distributed fairly, with tasks assigned according to individual strengths to ensure equal contribution.

7.2.2 Guidance from the Cooperation Contract

The Cooperation Contract established clear professional expectations from the start. It proved vital in resolving intercultural misunderstandings professionally, allowing the group to stay focused on project goals. Additionally, it provided a framework for strengths-based task allocation, which increased engagement and simulated a realistic corporate environment while ensuring individual accountability

7.3 Future Improvements

This final section reviews the overall execution of the project, from initial desk research to the final iteration of Prototype Version 2. Critical group takeaways are identified, and strategic adjustments for future assignments are specified.

7.3.1 General Project Reflection

The project successfully addressed the "Value Gap" for Mars Inc. The "Play & Share" concept effectively balanced consumer social needs with the company's requirements for brand differentiation and cost control. A structured research approach ensured that the concept was based on consumer data rather than assumptions, while effective time management preserved the quality of the final deliverables.

7.3.2 Lessons for the Future

This final evaluation highlights the primary internal lessons learned during the project and describes how these insights lead to specific strategic changes for future work.

Core Team Takeaways:

- **Ideation Mindset:** A key learning was the value of postponing judgment during the early brainstorming phase. Accepting creative or "wild" ideas initially often led to more practical and high-impact solutions later in the process.
- **Methodological Rigor:** Designing the instructor-commended survey question regarding the "Free Choice Scenario" taught the group how to move beyond basic responses to uncover deep consumer motivations.
- **Critical AI Literacy:** While AI tools were helpful for organizing and refining the report, it was learned that all AI-generated content requires careful human verification to ensure it is accurate and meets university standards.
- **Professional Documentation:** The use of meeting summaries (MoM) and task checklists ensured that the project remained organized and transparent, even when individual members were absent.

Strategic Adjustments:

- **Phygital Expansion:** If the project were to be expanded, a more robust "phygital" model would be recommended. This would involve a closer link between the physical board game and a digital web platform to better appeal to younger, tech-savvy consumers.
- **Proactive Technical Intervention:** Future projects would benefit from identifying and solving technical or conceptual confusion much earlier. Seeking guidance from instructors at the beginning of high-pressure phases would significantly improve time efficiency.
- **Field Research Optimization:** As international students, the group identified a language barrier during field research in Dutch stores. Future projects would benefit from partnering with native-speaking respondents or using professional translation to get deeper qualitative insights from the local target market.

Chapter 8: AI Use Disclosure

AI tools were integrated into the project as "thought partners" to enhance divergent thinking and refine the structural coherence of the final report. The use of these tools was strictly limited to augmenting human creativity and ensuring professional communication standards without replacing original critical analysis.

8.1 Project Management and Workload Distribution

AI assisted in the equitable distribution of tasks throughout the project to ensure a balanced workload and prevent favoritism. While AI proposed the initial division of labor, the team remained flexible, allowing members to contribute based on individual strengths and expertise to maximize project quality. Additionally, AI-generated checklists were utilized to track progress and ensure all components were delivered within the strict project deadlines.

8.2 Research and Prototype Development

AI tools supported the methodological phases of the project, though human oversight remained the primary driver:

- **Desk Research:** AI aided in the preliminary identification of market trends, but every data point presented in the report was manually verified for validity against primary and secondary sources.
- **Field Research Preparation:** Interview and survey questions were initially generated with AI assistance. However, these were subsequently modified through team discussion and teacher consultation to ensure alignment with the specific assignment objectives.
- **Prototype Visualization:** AI was utilized to create the initial visuals for the "Play & Share" prototype. Manual adjustments were then performed to ensure all text was accurate, readable, and functional for a physical board game.

8.3 Structural and Linguistic Refinement

Given that English is not the first language of the team members, AI was utilized to overcome language barriers and meet university standards for academic reporting:

- **Report Structure:** AI assisted in refining the overall flow and internal content organization of the chapters to maintain a professional narrative.
- **Academic Tone:** AI was employed to refine the vocabulary and tone, ensuring the report met formal academic requirements and eliminated personal pronouns as instructed.
- **Reference and Appendix Management:** To prevent human error or overlapping data, AI was utilized to structure references according to APA guidelines and organize the appendices in relation to the main document.

8.4 Integrity Statement

The use of AI in this project was strictly limited to organizational support, linguistic polishing, and divergent thinking assistance. All strategic decisions, research conclusions, and final prototype iterations were determined by the team based on empirical evidence and academic requirements.

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APPENDIXES

Appendix A: Research Methodology & Sample Description

Research Design To investigate consumer behaviour in the chocolate-bites category and understand the market share dynamics between Mars brands (M&M's/Maltesers) and private label alternatives, a quantitative survey was conducted. The study utilized a descriptive research design, aiming to collect structured data on purchasing behaviour, brand perception, taste evaluation, and price sensitivity.

Data Collection

- **Method:** Structured online survey (Google Forms).
- **Sampling Strategy:** Non-probability convenience sampling.
- **Distribution Channels:** Digital distribution via WhatsApp and Instagram; face-to-face intercepts using the digital survey.
- **Target Audience:** Consumers aged 16+ who purchase chocolate products in Dutch supermarkets.

Sample Description

A total of **64 valid responses** were collected. The sample represents a mix of students, working professionals, and older adults.

Table A 1: *Gender Distribution of Respondents*

Gender	Count	%
Female	38	59%
Male	25	39%
Other	1	2%
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure A1: *Gender Distribution of Respondents*

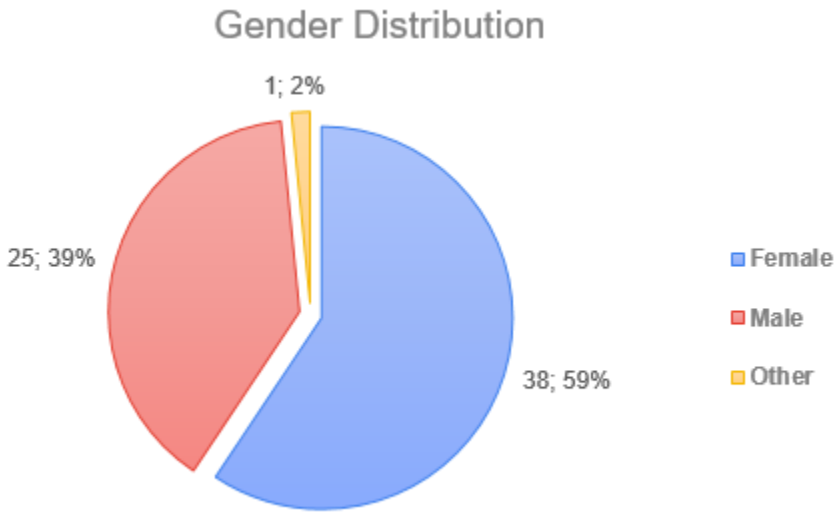


Table A 2: *Age Distribution of Respondents*

Age	Count	%
18-20	13	**20%**
21-25	17	**27%**
26-30	15	**23%**
31-40	4	**6%**
41-50	4	**6%**
51-60	3	**5%**
Above 60	8	**13%**
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure A2: *Age Distribution of Respondents*

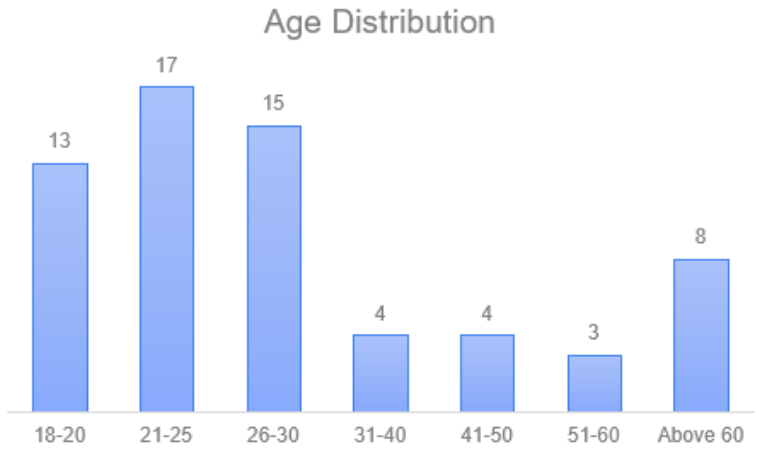
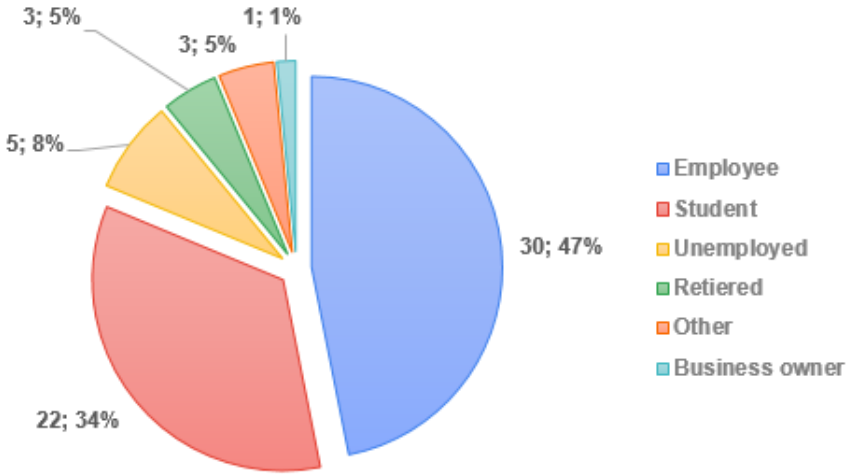


Table A 3: *Profession Profile of Respondents*

Profession	Count	%
Employee	30	**47%**
Student	22	**34%**
Unemployed	5	**8%**
Retired	3	**5%**
Other	3	**5%**
Business owner	1	**2%**
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure A3: *Profession Profile of Respondents*



Appendix B: Survey Questions & Quantitative Results

This section presents the specific questions asked to respondents and the aggregated quantitative data derived from the 64 completed surveys.

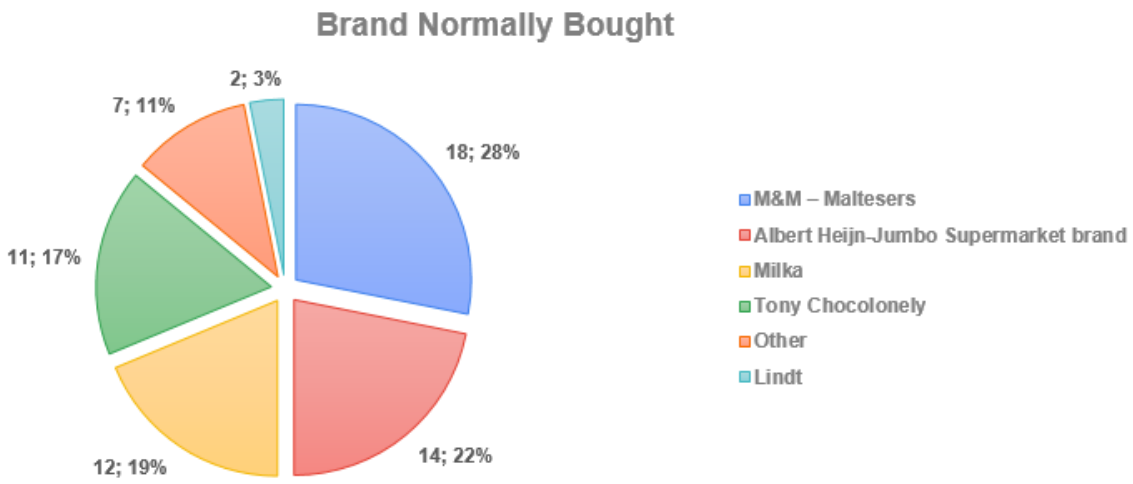
Part 1: General Purchasing Behaviour

Q1: Which brand of chocolate bites do you normally buy?

Table B 1: *Brand Normally Bought.*

	Brand mentioned most often	Count	%
	M&M – Maltesers	18	28%
	Albert Heijn-Jumbo Supermarket brand	14	22%
	Milka	12	19%
	Tony Chocolonely	11	17%
	Lindt	2	3%
These are the other option with open answers Count 7/11%	Ferrero Rocher	1	2%
	Goedkope uit Duitsland	1	2%
	I cant remember the last time I bought chocolate	1	2%
	Lidl chocolade	1	2%
	Lindt, Milka, Plus supermarket brand	1	2%
	Niet	1	2%
	None	1	2%
	Grand Total	**64**	

Figure B1: *Brand Normally Bought.*

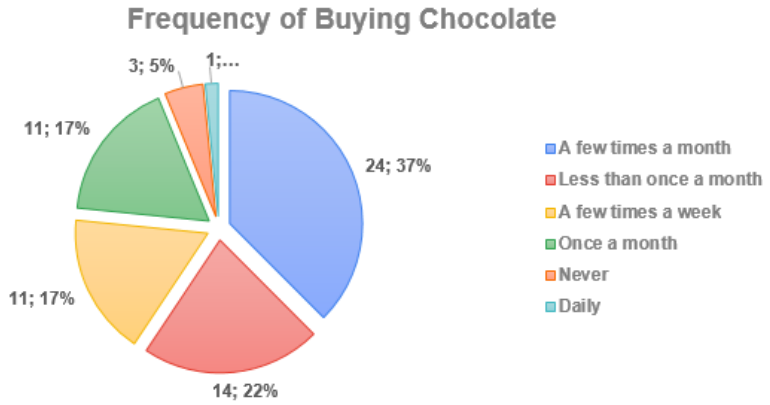


Q2: How often do you buy chocolate?

Table B 2: *Frequency of Chocolate Consumption.*

Frequency of Buying Chocolate	Count	%
A few times a month	24	**38%**
Less than once a month	14	**22%**
A few times a week	11	**17%**
Once a month	11	**17%**
Never	3	**5%**
Daily	1	**2%**
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure B2: *Frequency of Chocolate Consumption.*

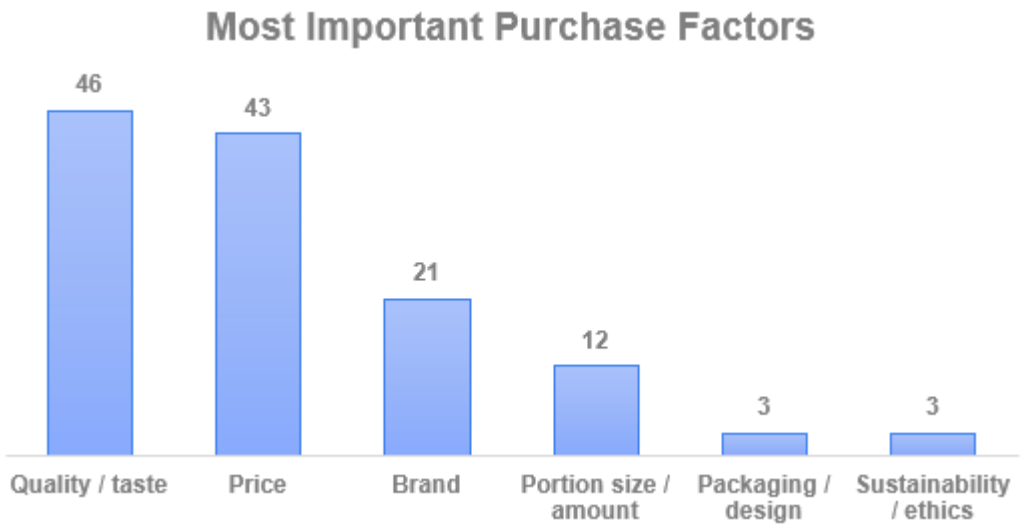


Question3: When choosing chocolate, what are the 2 most important things you consider?

Table B 3: *Most Important Purchase Factors.*

Factor	Selected how often	% of respondents (rough, 64 = 100%)
Quality / taste	46	~72%
Price	43	~67%
Brand	21	~33%
Portion size / amount	12	~19%
Packaging / design	3	~5%
Sustainability / ethics	3	~5%

Figure B3: *Most Important Purchase Factors.*



Part 2: Brand Preference & Occasions

Q4: Which of the following best describes your purchasing behaviour regarding chocolate bites?

Table B 4: *Purchasing Behaviour Patterns*

Behaviour pattern	Count	%
I prefer well-known brands but will buy Supermarket brands (e.g Albert Heijn or Jumbo) if it's cheaper	28	**44%**
I only buy well-known brands	19	**30%**
I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	14	**22%**
I prefer Supermarket brands (e.g Albert Heijn or Jumbo)	3	**5%**
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure B4: *Purchasing Behaviour Patterns*

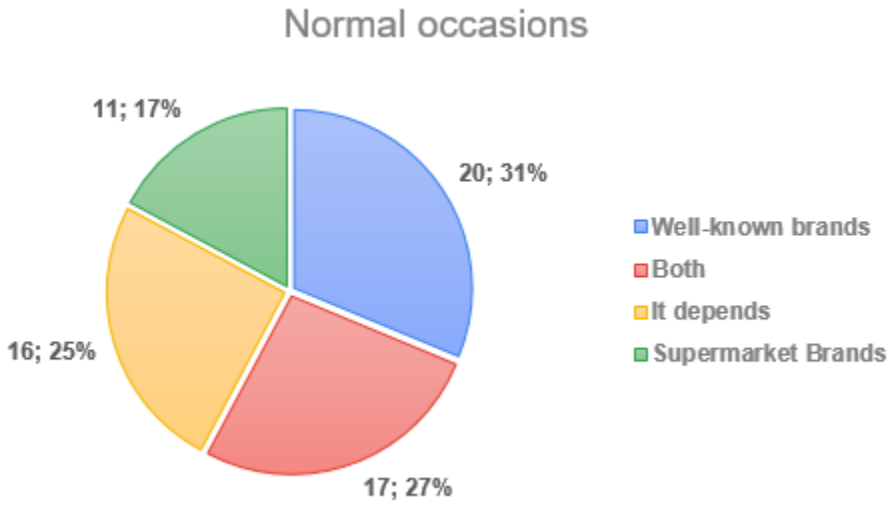


Q5: For normal occasions like watching movies, which brand do you normally get?

Table B 5: *Brand Choice for Normal Occasions*

Choice	Count	%
Well-known brands	20	**31%**
Both	17	**27%**
It depends	16	**25%**
Supermarket Brands	11	**17%**
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure B5: *Brand Choice for Normal Occasions*

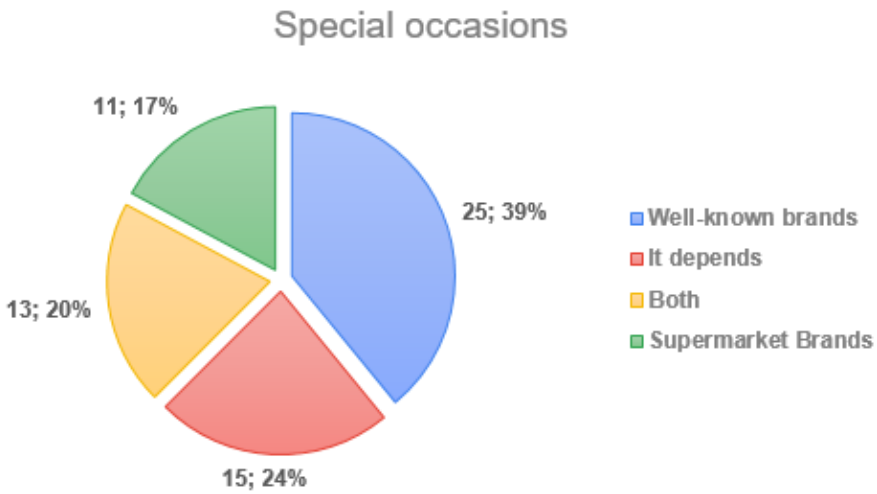


Q6: For special occasions like party, which brand do you normally get?

Table B 6: *Brand Choice for Special Occasions*

Choice	Count	%
Well-known brands	25	**39%**
It depends	15	**23%**
Both	13	**20%**
Supermarket Brands	11	**17%**
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure B6: *Brand Choice for Special Occasions*



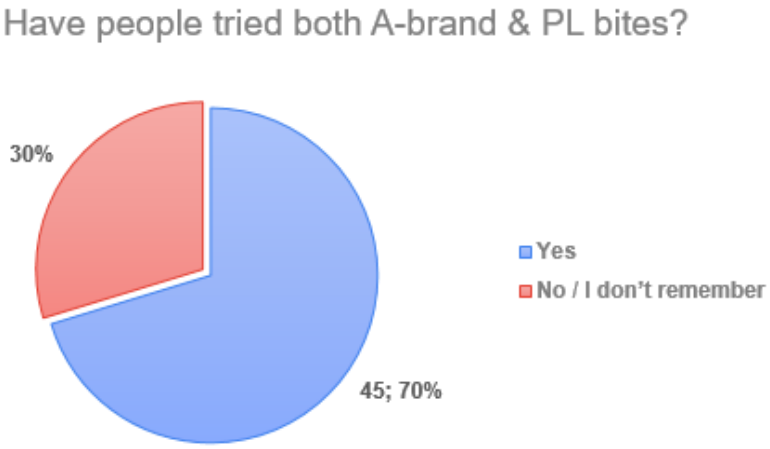
Part 3: Taste & Comparison

Q7: Have you tried both A-brand & Private Label bites?

Table B 7: *Experience with A-Brand and Private Label*

Answer	Count	%
Yes	45	**70%**
No / I don't remember	19	**30%**
Grand Total	64	

Figure B7: *Experience with A-Brand and Private Label*

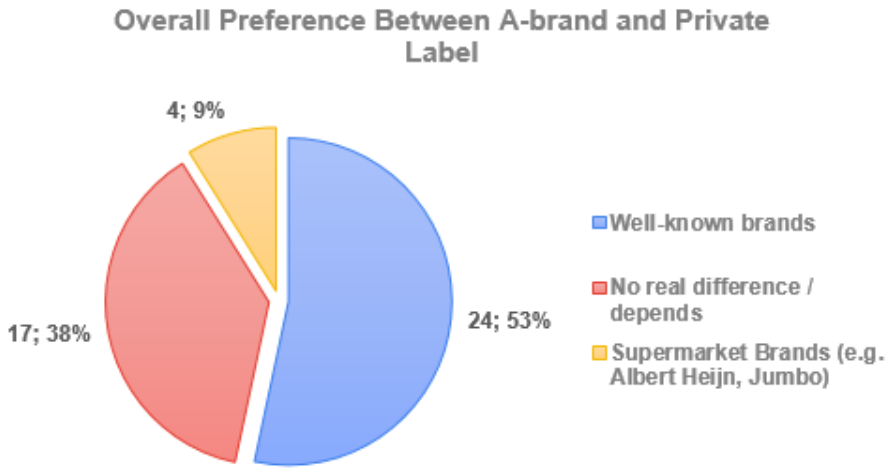


Q8: Which did you like better overall? (Asked to those who tried both)

Table B 8: *Overall Preference*

Preference	Count	%
Well-known brands	24	53%
No real difference / depends	17	38%
Supermarket Brands (e.g. Albert Heijn, Jumbo)	4	9%
Grand Total	**45**	

Figure B8: *Overall Preference*

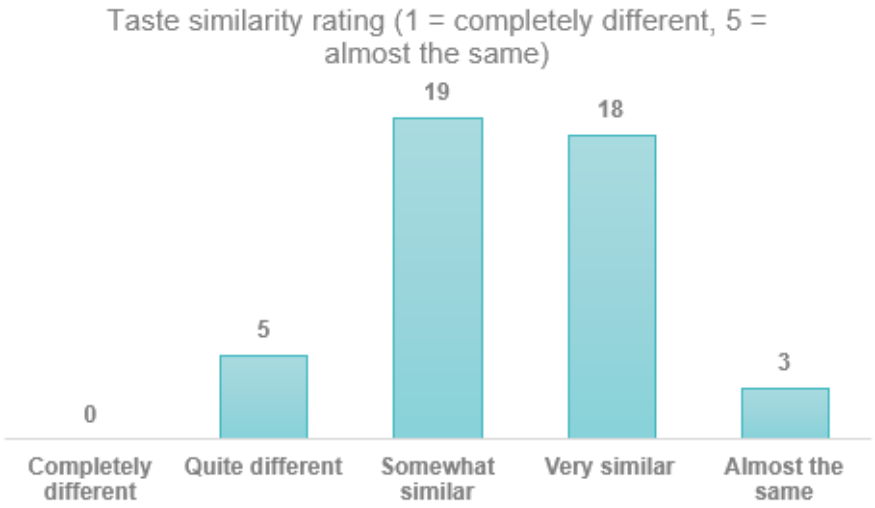


Q9: On a scale of 1 to 5, how similar do you think the taste is?

Table B 9: *Perceived Taste Similarity Ratings*

Score	Meaning	Count	%
1	Completely different	0	**0%**
2	Quite different	5	**11%**
3	**Somewhat similar**	19	**42%**
4	**Very similar**	18	**40%**
5	Almost the same	3	**7%**

Figure B9: *Perceived Taste Similarity Ratings*



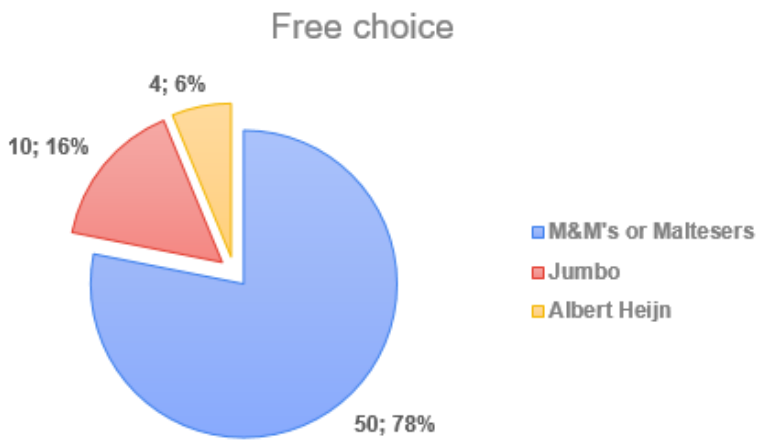
Part 4: Value & Budget

Q10: If you could get one of these chocolate bites bags for free, which product group would you choose?

Table B 10: *Brand Choice in Free Scenario*

Option chosen	Count	%
M&M's or Maltesers	50	78%
Jumbo	10	16%
Albert Heijn	4	6%
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure B10: *Brand Choice in Free Scenario*

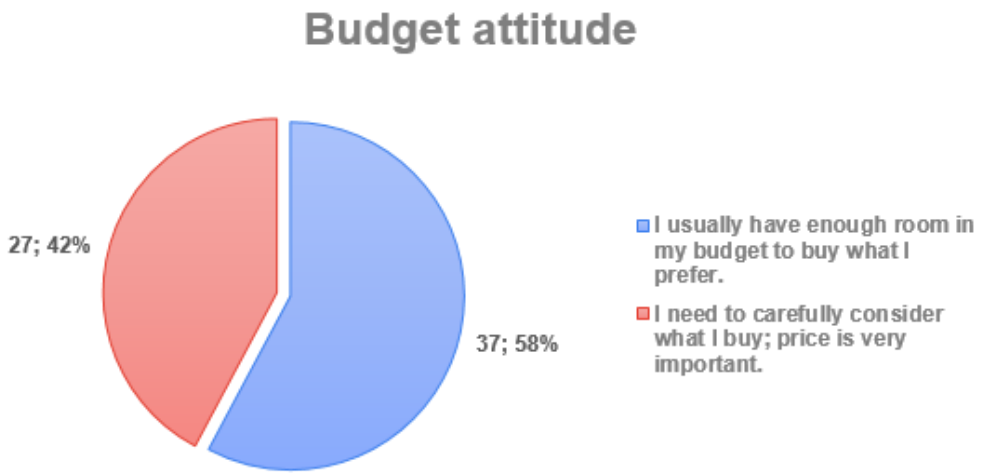


Q11: Which of these fits you better when it comes to groceries?

Table B 11: *Grocery Budget Constraint*

Budget attitude	Count	%
I usually have enough room in my budget to buy what I prefer.	37	**58%**
I need to carefully consider what I buy; price is very important.	27	**42%**
Grand Total	**64**	

Figure B11: *Grocery Budget Constraint*



Appendix C: Qualitative Analysis (Open Questions)

The following tables summarize the thematic analysis of the open-ended survey questions. Responses were coded to identify recurring patterns in consumer reasoning.

1. Why do people choose Supermarket brands instead of well-known brands?

Table C 1: *Reasons for Choosing Supermarket Brands*

Theme	Approx. mentions
Lower price / saving money	**57**
Taste is (almost) the same as A-brands	11 (often *together* with price)
Better quantity / value (more in the bag)	1
Seasonal variants / variety	1
Comfort / certainty / habit	2
Ethical / political reasons (e.g. boycott)	1

Key insights:

1. Lower price or saving money is the dominant factor and seen as a "rational" choice.
2. People use Private Labels mainly as a value strategy: "good enough" taste at a clearly lower price.

Typical quotes (paraphrased)

- “Cheaper and almost the same taste.”
- “Same flavour for half the price.”
- “They are cheaper and still taste good.”
- One explicit boycott of certain companies.

2. Which packaging do you like the best? Why?
Options: (1) M&M's, (2) Albert Heijn, (3) Jumbo

Table C 2: *Packaging Preferences*

Preference	**Observation**	**Common Reasons Given**
Option 1 (M&M's)	**Preferred by ~44 respondents**	"Playful character", "Fun look", "Premium feeling", "Recognizable/Trusted".
Option 2 & 3 (PL)	Minority preference	"Elegant", "Vibrant colors", "Exciting".

Key insight: Visually, M&M's still wins strongly. The brand world and characters are a big asset.

Common reasons:

- Playful character or fun look (“Cute M&M figure”, “More playful and pleasant”)
- Brand familiarity or trust (“I know what I get”, “Because it's M&M”)
- Premium or quality perception (“Looks more premium”, “Visually attractive”)
- Clear product information (“You see what is inside or the filling”)

3. What do you think is the difference between products on eye level and lower shelf?

Most respondents gave marketing and price-based explanations.

Main Pattern:

- Big brands & more expensive products on eye level
- Cheaper or Private Label brands lower down
- Eye level = more attention, easier to grab; lower shelf = less visible, sometimes aimed at children
- A few say, “No real difference for me”.

Insight: Consumers are highly aware of the commercial logic behind shelf placement. They associate eye-level products with expensive A-brands, while lower shelf products with cheaper deals.

4. Do you ever feel like the 'big brands' are worth the extra money? What exactly do you think you are paying for?

Answers are clearly mixed:

- A substantial group says yes. Mostly because of better taste and quality, and sometimes ethical sourcing (e.g. Tony's, sustainability).
- Others are ambivalent. They feel they are paying mostly for the brand name and marketing, but still occasionally buy it "because it's nice" or for special occasions.
- A clear group says no. They believe quality is almost the same, so the premium is not justified.

Themes:

- Paying for quality or taste
- Paying for brand, advertising, reputation and "legacy"
- Paying for ethics or fair trade in some cases
- Some strong "No, you pay only for the name" reactions

Insight: Brand equity still exists, but it is fragile. If Private Label's quality is perceived as equal, many consumers rationally prefer the cheaper product.

5. (Follow-up of Q10) Why choose that free bag option?

Reasons for choosing mostly Group 1 (M&M/Maltesers):

- Familiar taste, trusted brand ("I know them", "you are sure of the taste")
- Premium feeling or more expensive normally (so free = high value)
- Love for nuts, raisins or hazelnut in those mixes
- Attractive packaging and colors
- Some mention saving the most money by picking the normally expensive brand.

A few who picked PL group did it because:

- "Tastes the same, cheaper normally"
- "Best recipe while saving money".

Insight: When money is not a barrier, M&M and Maltesers are still the aspirational choice. Private Label wins mainly because of price, not brand love.

Appendix D: Raw Dataset

Legend:

- **ID:** Respondent Number
- **Gen:** Gender
- **Age:** Age group
- **Prof:** Profession
- **Q1:** Brand Normally Bought
- **Q2:** Consumption Frequency
- **Q3:** Top 2 Factors
- **Q4:** Purchasing Behaviour
- **Q5:** Normal Occasion Choice
- **Q6:** Special Occasion Choice
- **Q7:** Tried Both?
- **Q8:** Preference (if tried both)
- **Q9:** Taste Similarity (1-5)
- **Q10:** Free Choice

Table D 1: *Demographics & Habits (ID, Gender, Age, Profession, Q1, Q2, Q3, Q11)*

ID	Gen	Age	Profession	Q1 (Brand)	Q2 (Freq)	Q3 (Factors)	Q11 (Budget)
1	Female	18-20	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...
2	Female	18-20	Student	M&M – Maltesers	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
3	Male	21-25	Student	M&M – Maltesers	Once a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...
4	Male	26-30	Employee	Tony Chocolonely	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Sustainability / ethics	I usually have enough room...
5	Female	21-25	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Portion size / amount	I need to carefully consider...
6	Female	21-25	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
7	Female	26-30	Employee	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Portion size / amount	I need to carefully consider...
8	Male	26-30	Employee	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...
9	Male	21-25	Student	Tony Chocolonely	A few times a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...
10	Female	18-20	Student	Tony Chocolonely	Once a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...
11	Female	18-20	Student	Milka	Once a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
12	Male	21-25	Student	Milka	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...

13	Female	26-30	Employee	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
14	Female	31-40	Employee	Milka	A few times a month	Quality / taste, Portion size / amount	I usually have enough room...
15	Male	41-50	Employee	Tony Chocolonely	Less than once a month	Brand, Sustainability / ethics	I usually have enough room...
16	Female	51-60	Employee	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Portion size / amount	I need to carefully consider...
17	Male	Above 60	Retired	Lindt	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
18	Female	26-30	Employee	Tony Chocolonely	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
19	Female	18-20	Student	Milka	A few times a week	Quality / taste, Portion size / amount	I need to carefully consider...
20	Male	21-25	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	Once a month	Price, Quantity	I need to carefully consider...
21	Female	18-20	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Brand	I need to carefully consider...
22	Female	21-25	Employee	M&M – Maltesers	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
23	Male	26-30	Employee	Milka	Once a month	Quality / taste, Price	I need to carefully consider...
24	Male	31-40	Employee	M&M – Maltesers	A few times a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...

25	Female	41-50	Employee	Tony Chocolonely	Once a month	Quality / taste, Sustainability / ethics	I usually have enough room...
26	Male	Above 60	Retired	Other	A few times a week	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
27	Female	21-25	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
28	Male	18-20	Student	M&M – Maltesers	Less than once a month	Brand, Price	I need to carefully consider...
29	Female	26-30	Employee	Milka	A few times a month	Quality / taste, Portion size / amount	I usually have enough room...
30	Male	21-25	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
31	Female	18-20	Student	M&M – Maltesers	Once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
32	Female	51-60	Employee	Milka	A few times a month	Quality / taste, Price	I need to carefully consider...
33	Male	26-30	Employee	M&M – Maltesers	A few times a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...
34	Female	21-25	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Portion size / amount	I need to carefully consider...
35	Male	18-20	Student	Tony Chocolonely	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
36	Female	31-40	Business owner	Lindt	A few times a week	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
37	Male	41-50	Employee	M&M – Maltesers	Less than once a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...

38	Female	Above 60	Retired	Other	Once a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
39	Male	21-25	Student	M&M – Maltesers	A few times a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
40	Female	26-30	Employee	Milka	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
41	Female	18-20	Student	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
42	Male	21-25	Student	Tony Chocolonely	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
43	Female	26-30	Employee	Milka	A few times a month	Quality / taste, Price	I usually have enough room...
44	Male	51-60	Unemployed	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a week	Price, Quantity	I need to carefully consider...
45	Female	Above 60	Other	Other	Once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
46	Male	18-20	Student	M&M – Maltesers	A few times a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...
47	Female	21-25	Employee	Tony Chocolonely	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
48	Female	26-30	Employee	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
49	Male	31-40	Unemployed	Milka	A few times a week	Price, Portion size / amount	I need to carefully consider...
50	Female	41-50	Unemployed	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
51	Male	Above 60	Other	Other	Less than once a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...

52	Female	18-20	Student	M&M – Maltesers	Once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
53	Male	21-25	Employee	Tony Chocolonely	A few times a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
54	Female	26-30	Employee	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Portion size / amount	I need to carefully consider...
55	Male	18-20	Student	Milka	A few times a week	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
56	Female	21-25	Student	M&M – Maltesers	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
57	Female	Above 60	Other	Other	Once a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
58	Male	26-30	Employee	Tony Chocolonely	A few times a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
59	Female	31-40	Unemployed	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	A few times a month	Price, Quantity	I need to carefully consider...
60	Male	41-50	Unemployed	Milka	A few times a week	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
61	Female	Above 60	Retired	Other	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...
62	Male	21-25	Student	M&M – Maltesers	A few times a month	Brand, Quality / taste	I usually have enough room...
63	Female	26-30	Employee	Albert Heijn-Jumbo	Once a month	Price, Quality / taste	I need to carefully consider...
64	Other	Above 60	Retired	Other	Less than once a month	Quality / taste, Brand	I usually have enough room...

Table D 2: *Preferences & Opinions (ID, Q4, Q5, Q6, Q7, Q8, Q9, Q10)*

ID	Q4 (Behaviour)	Q5 (Normal)	Q6 (Special)	Q7 (Tried Both)	Q8 (Pref)	Q9 (Sim)	Q10 (Free)
1	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	No real difference / depends	2	Jumbo
2	I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	It depends	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	4	M&M's or Maltesers
3	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	3	M&M's or Maltesers
4	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	Supermarket Brands	No / I don't remember	-	3	Jumbo
5	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
6	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
7	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	It depends	It depends	Yes	Well-known brands	3	M&M's or Maltesers
8	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	It depends	It depends	Yes	Well-known brands	3	M&M's or Maltesers
9	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
10	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
11	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	3	M&M's or Maltesers

12	I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	Both	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	3	M&M's or Maltesers
13	I prefer Supermarket brands	Supermarket Brands	Supermarket Brands	Yes	Supermarket Brands	5	Albert Heijn
14	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	It depends	It depends	Yes	Well-known brands	3	M&M's or Maltesers
15	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
16	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	It depends	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	Jumbo
17	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
18	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	3	M&M's or Maltesers
19	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	Well-known brands	4	M&M's or Maltesers
20	I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	Supermarket Brands	Supermarket Brands	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	Jumbo
21	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	It depends	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
22	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
23	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	3	M&M's or Maltesers
24	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
25	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers

26	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	It depends	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
27	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
28	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
29	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	Well-known brands	3	M&M's or Maltesers
30	I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	Supermarket Brands	Supermarket Brands	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	Jumbo
31	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
32	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	3	M&M's or Maltesers
33	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
34	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
35	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
36	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
37	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
38	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	It depends	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
39	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers

40	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	Well-known brands	3	M&M's or Maltesers
41	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
42	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
43	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	Well-known brands	3	M&M's or Maltesers
44	I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	Supermarket Brands	Supermarket Brands	Yes	Supermarket Brands	5	Jumbo
45	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
46	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
47	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
48	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	Jumbo
49	I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	Supermarket Brands	Supermarket Brands	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
50	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	It depends	Yes	No real difference / depends	3	Albert Heijn
51	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
52	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
53	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers

54	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	Jumbo
55	I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	Supermarket Brands	Supermarket Brands	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	M&M's or Maltesers
56	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
57	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	It depends	Yes	No real difference / depends	4	Jumbo
58	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
59	I have no preference, I buy whatever is on sale	Supermarket Brands	Supermarket Brands	Yes	Supermarket Brands	5	Jumbo
60	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Both	Both	Yes	No real difference / depends	3	Albert Heijn
61	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	No / I don't remember	-	2	M&M's or Maltesers
62	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers
63	I prefer well-known brands but will buy...	Supermarket Brands	It depends	Yes	No real difference / depends	3	Albert Heijn
64	I only buy well-known brands	Well-known brands	Well-known brands	Yes	Well-known brands	2	M&M's or Maltesers

Appendix E: Brainstorming Process

The ideation phase was characterized by a structured Design Thinking workflow designed to bridge the "Value Gap" identified in the initial research. This appendix documents the divergent thinking process, which resulted in a backlog of 200 unique ideas. The information presented includes photographic evidence of the physical brainstorming sessions and a systematic inventory of all concepts, categorized according to their placement in the COCD Box matrix (see Chapter 3).

Figure E 1: *Photographic Documentation of the Collaborative Brainstorming Session*



Description: This figure provides visual evidence of the divergent thinking phase where the first 50 ideas were generated.

Table E 2: *Systematic Inventory of Generated Ideas (1–200) with COCD Categorization*

ID	Concept Description	Category
1	Campaign highlighting A-brand advantages over private labels	
2	Packs featuring various small chocolate bars	
3	"Fortune Cookie" style bars with paper inserts	Blue
4	Question and answer pairs across different packs	
5	Quiz requiring letter combinations to win a prize	Red
6	Christmas packaging for December	
7	Various 3-for-1 promotional offers	
8	M&M's open store meetings	
9	"Gender Reveal" packaging (blue or pink)	Red

10	**Origami paper packaging with folding instructions**	
11	**Chocolate in cartoon character shapes**	
12	**Paid promotional campaigns**	
13	**National flags printed on chocolates**	
14	**Liquid-filled chocolate centers**	
15	**Design for single-handed consumption**	**Yellow**
16	**Vaping products in M&M's flavors**	
17	**Life milestone stories for brand characters**	**Yellow**
18	**Printed pictures for puzzle-solving before consumption**	
19	**Integration of herbs/botanicals in products**	
20	**Trend-driven product marketing**	

21	**Development of new or mixed flavors**	
22	**M&M's and Maltesers integrated ice cream**	**Blue**
23	**Collaborative film production with Disney**	**Yellow**
24	**Loyalty programs offering discounts or benefits**	**Blue**
25	**Cross-brand cake collaborations**	
26	**"Buy one, get one free" offers**	
27	**Inclusion of cocoa seeds for home cultivation**	**Red**
28	**Small toys included inside the packaging**	
29	**Zero sugar or healthy product variants**	**Blue**
30	**Development of a product-themed video game**	**Yellow**
31	**Strategic price reductions and offers**	**Red**

32	**Language learning integration with packaging**	
33	**Workshops for personalized chocolate creation**	
34	**Ginger bread house decoration kits**	
35	**Integration of products into birthday traditions**	
36	**Development of allergy-safe chocolates**	**Blue**
37	**Social "get to know" or party questions**	**Blue**
38	**Personalized packaging inspired by Lego**	**Blue**
39	**Online prize-linked questions**	
40	**Chocolate with associated musical notes**	
41	**Launch of seasonal flavors (e.g., matcha, cinnamon)**	**Blue**
42	**Upgraded premium packaging**	

43	**Recipe-based marketing strategies**	
44	**Collectible comic-style stones on packaging**	
45	**Flavor creation through specific color combinations**	**Yellow**
46	**"BeanBoozled" inspired party variant**	**Blue**
47	**Protein-fortified chocolate bites**	**Red**
48	**In-pack lottery tickets for external events**	
49	**Strategic promotion of specific "snack moments"**	**Red**
50	**Fortified wellness products targeted at women**	**Yellow**
51	**Implementation of targeted student discounts**	**Red**
52	**Specialized gift boxes for milestones**	**Blue**
53	**Packaging featuring brand heritage and fun facts**	

54	**Mystery flavor guessing games with digital prizes**	
55	**Seasonal candy shapes (e.g., hearts, pumpkins)**	**Blue**
56	**Product expansion into the cereal category**	
57	**Interactive displays within supermarkets**	**Yellow**
58	**Introduction of "City Edition" flavors**	**Red**
59	**Savory-sweet chocolate variants**	**Blue**
60	**Gaming partnership for digital rewards (Roblox/Fortnite)**	**Yellow**
61	**"Artisan Collection" featuring small-batch coatings**	
62	**"Golden Ticket" style ingredient upgrades**	**Red**
63	**Single-color "Palette" packs with minimalist design**	
64	**"Brain Boost" edition for cognitive focus**	**Yellow**

65	**AR-enabled recipe demonstrations**	
66	**Paid "Masterclass" platform for chocolate making**	
67	**Temperature-sensitive enjoyment indicators**	
68	**Premium reusable metal or ceramic canisters**	
69	**Scented product variants**	**Yellow**
70	**Post-workout variants with specific carb-protein ratios**	
71	**Monthly "Collector's Coin" themed packaging**	
72	**"Taste of History" historical cocoa facts**	
73	**Customizable messages inside chocolate shells**	
74	**Cross-brand culinary collaborations**	**Yellow**
75	**Personalized flavor-blending kiosks**	

76	**Zero-waste carbon offset programs**	
77	**AI-driven predictive flavor digital campaigns**	
78	**Gamified loyalty tiers for brand ambassadors**	
79	**"Cultural Heritage" themed color palettes**	
80	**Sommelier-style pairing kits and guides**	
81	**Vending machine specific packaging**	
82	**Mixed variety bags (peanut, crispy, caramel)**	
83	**Enhanced easy-open packaging design**	
84	**Integrated recipes using brand products**	
85	**"Red Ribbon" gift-style opening mechanism**	**Blue**
86	**Temperature-dependent color-shifting packs**	

87	**"Confetti Burst" opening mechanism**	
88	**Film-peel artwork reveals**	
89	**Flavor-tinted transparent viewing windows**	
90	**Mood-dependent color-shifting packaging**	
91	**Elastic wrist/bag snap-band packaging**	
92	**"Tap Cap" single-release mechanism**	
93	**Heat-reveal thermochromic secret messages**	**Yellow**
94	**Multiple pouches bound in an "Edible Passport"**	
95	**Refillable ceramic tile decorative containers**	
96	**"Hourglass" shaped transparent flow chamber**	
97	**Unfolding "Petal" gift-style packaging**	

98	**Retractable "Candy Tape Measure"**	
99	**Sculpted abstract "Nest" style cartons**	
100	**Circular ring-shaped packaging**	
101	**Road trip "Passenger Princess" easy-pour spout**	
102	**Extra crunchy "Spoiler Blocker" packs**	
103	**Office "Icebreaker" jars with conversation lids**	
104	**"Date Night Decision Maker" integrated game**	**Red**
105	**Checkout counter "Apology" mini-packs**	
106	**Coffee shop specific "Motivation" pairings**	
107	**Coins/dice to settle "The Last One" disputes**	
108	**RPG "Health Potion" hit-point counters**	

109	**Genre-specific book club genre pairings**	
110	**Gaming headset stand-compatible "Respawn" tubes**	
111	**Dual-compartment "Gym Buddy" workout/spotter splits**	
112	**Live "Twitch Raid" snack delivery integration**	
113	**Trackable geocaching "Travel Bug" codes**	
114	**Festival-ready waterproof carabiner packaging**	**Yellow**
115	**Silent, non-crinkle "Library Quiet" material**	**Red**
116	**Comfort-food flavor "Breakup Recovery" kits**	
117	**Silent-opening energy boosted "New Parent" fuel**	
118	**Subscription "Empty Nest" voice-note care packs**	
119	**Randomized flavor "Chaos Mix" for astrological moods**	

120	**Rewards for completing "Adulting Wins" tasks**	
121	**Meditation-linked "Sunday Scaries" antidote**	
122	**In-tray pixel art grid using colored candies**	
123	**Projector tubes for wall-based storytelling**	
124	**Interactive "Color-by-Candy" social placemats**	**Red**
125	**Edible "Paint" kits using candy shells**	**Blue**
126	**Wrappers unfolding into sturdy standing bowls**	
127	**STEM-focused "Physics of Crunch" experiments**	
128	**"Sound Amplifier" maraca-style rhythmic boxes**	
129	**QR codes for personalized deep-fake character videos**	**Red**
130	**"Local Legend" street artist collectible series**	

131	**"Meet the Farmer" traceability codes**	
132	**Throwback vintage 80s and 90s packaging**	
133	**Single "Veto Power" candies for film/dinner choices**	
134	**Discounted "Ugly" misshapen candy waste reduction**	
135	**Halftime-only flash-discount app delivery**	
136	**"Reunion" terminal specific airport gift packs**	
137	**"Traffic Jam" glovebox mood lift kits**	
138	**Integrated checkout queue mini-games**	
139	**24-hour convenience "Night Shift" energy**	**Red**
140	**Cooling vs. warming "Temperature Roulette"**	
141	**Mixed weight and density "Texture Clash" boxes**	

142	**Tongue-dying "Blue Mouth" sleepover prank packs**	
143	**Sensory "Fizz Coating" soda reaction**	
144	**Coffee scent-releasing "Scent-Scapes" seals**	
145	**Random "Golden Ticket" NFT party invites**	
146	**Multi-user "Friendship Bracelet" scanning codes**	
147	**AR-enabled "Tabletop Sports" phone goalposts**	
148	**Recorded digital "Message in a Bottle" transfers**	**Red**
149	**Unlocked Snapchat/TikTok character head filters**	
150	**Live national "Cats or Dogs?" polling barcodes**	
151	**Confetti party bags**	**Yellow**
152	**Mixed flavor "Party Mix" bags**	**Blue**

153	**Occasion-themed seasonal packaging**	**Blue**
154	**Pre-filled colorful "Party Bowls"**	**Blue**
155	**Resealable "Mega Party Tubs"**	
156	**Customizable gift packs for specific events**	**Blue**
157	**Branded party confetti cannons**	**Red**
158	**Curated party playlists via QR codes**	**Yellow**
159	**Branded party cups filled with chocolate**	
160	**Bundled snack and decoration "Host Kits"**	
161	**Volume-based "Bring M&M's" party discounts**	**Blue**
162	**Branded social party table centerpieces**	
163	**Pre-mixed "Sharing Moments" M&M/Maltesers bags**	

164	**Night-event glow-in-the-dark packaging**	
165	**Party-themed edible cake toppings**	**Blue**
166	**Occasion-specific balloon-shaped packaging**	
167	**Elegant "Wedding Moments" guest table boxes**	**Red**
168	**Randomized "Surprise Me" flavor bags**	
169	**In-bag treasure hunt clues and puzzles**	
170	**Metallic VIP edition metallic packaging**	
171	**Integrated Dice-Roll Social Challenge (Selected Concept)**	**Red**
172	**Mixed bag and confetti cookie sets**	
173	**Color-coordinated party theme bags**	
174	**"Superhost" snack and decoration guarantees**	

175	**Floating LED spheres with chocolate**	**Yellow**
176	**"Party Shield" packaging serving tray**	**Red**
177	**Gaming night "Power-Up" specialized packs**	
178	**Pop-sound and light "Instant Party" bags**	
179	**Reflective mini-disco ball bag design**	**Yellow**
180	**Weightless/levitation inspired superhero versions**	
181	**Individual party guest mini-tubes**	
182	**Edible chocolate shot glasses**	**Red**
183	**Throw-safe durable party pouches**	
184	**Edible rope "Streamer Strings"**	
185	**Game-centric packaging replacing nutritional labels**	**Red**

186	**Intentional high-noise celebratory packaging**	
187	**Firework-cracking sound effect chocolates**	
188	**Celebratory sound-triggered opening mechanism**	
189	**"Memory Box" with photo space**	
190	**Giftable ribbon-included jars**	**Blue**
191	**Customizable "Make-a-Memory" printed messages**	
192	**Keepsake photo frame on packaging**	
193	**Branded social media hashtag campaign**	
194	**Social challenges and fun facts on wrappers**	**Red**
195	**Theme-based collectible party stickers**	
196	**Truth-or-dare "Moment Cards" in-bag**	

197	**High-visibility neon special editions**	
198	**Confetti-bomb shaped stand-out bags**	
199	**Partnerships for in-event table placement**	
200	**In-store personalized named packaging**	

Appendix F: Assumptions of the Selected Idea

To ensure the project remained academically robust and empirically driven, 18 core assumptions were formulated to test the viability, feasibility, and desirability of the proposed "Play & Share" concept. These assumptions are grounded in the initial market research and specifically address the identified 82% taste similarity gap and the needs of the 42% price-sensitive consumer demographic. The following table serves as the foundational "logic" for the Lean Experiments conducted during the validation phase (see Chapter 5).

Table F 1: *Comprehensive List of Assumptions*

Category	#	Assumption
Desirability	1	Consumers are seeking a "social experience" during snacking moments (e.g., parties or movies) where Mars brands are currently preferred.
	2	The 18–30 age demographic values "gamification" as a method to differentiate a premium snack from a generic alternative.
	3	The "playful character and fun look" of M&M's packaging is effectively extended through a physical game board.
	4	Users find it enjoyable to utilize food as game pieces, despite the requirement for more frequent product handling.
	5	Rotating monthly or seasonal games create a "collectible" urge, increasing purchase frequency.
	6	The experiential value of the game outweighs the 82% perceived taste similarity between private labels and Mars products.
Feasibility	7	A foldable, grease-proof paper board is insertable into the bag without altering existing outer packaging dimensions.
	8	Chocolate dust or oil from the candies does not compromise the legibility of the game board over time.

	9	The production line can accommodate the high-speed insertion of a non-food item without increasing candy breakage rates.
	10	A game can be designed for play without external tools by utilizing digital dice (QR codes) or "blind grab" mechanics.
	11	The bag contains sufficient volume for the board without requiring a reduction in chocolate weight.
Viability	12	The 42% of "price-constrained" shoppers view the board game as an "added value" that justifies the price gap with private labels.
	13	The cost of printing and inserting the board is low enough to avoid a further retail price increase.
	14	This unique feature motivates retailers to provide M&M's more "Eye Level" shelf space.
	15	The emotional brand loyalty (78% "Free Choice" preference) is convertible into rational purchases via this functional benefit.
	16	The game does not extend "snacking time" to a point that reduces the total amount of chocolate consumed.
	17	The cost of the board is absorbable through the existing marketing budget rather than being added to the Cost of Goods Sold (COGS).
	18	Increased sales volume and market share recovery offset the decrease in profit margin caused by the board's production.

Appendix G: Response Data of Lean Experiments

This appendix contains empirical evidence gathered from 17 respondents within the target demographic. The data is divided into quantitative performance metrics and qualitative consumer sentiment to justify the strategic decisions made for the "Play & Share" concept.

G.1 Aggregated Quantitative Results (N=17)

Table G 1: *Raw Respondent Scores for Core Assumptions*

Respondent	Social Appeal (1–5)	Price Justification	Rule Clarity (1–5)	Fun Factor (1–5)	Differentiation (1–5)
R1	5	5*	5	5	5
R2	5	Yes	5	5	5
R3	3	Yes	3	4	5
R4	4	Yes	4	2	5
R5	5	Maybe	5	5	5
R6	3	Yes	3	4	4
R7	4	Maybe	5	4	3
R8	5	No	4	5	5
R9	3	Maybe	1	4	4

R10	3	No	4	2	2
R11	4	Yes	5	4	4
R12	4	Maybe	5	3	5
R13	5	Yes	3	4	4
R14	4	Maybe	4	3	4
R15	4	No	2	4	1
R16	1	No	1	3	1
R17	3	Maybe	3	3	4
MEAN	**3.82**	**—**	**3.65**	**3.76**	**3.88**

***Note:** Respondent 1 provided a numerical score of 5 for price justification instead of a categorical response.*

Table G 2: *Summary of Quantitative Validation Metrics*

Metric	Mean Score	Success Rate (Top-2 Box)	Validation Status
Social Appeal	3.82	64.7%	**GO**
Price Justification	—	76.5% (Yes/Maybe)	**GO**
Rule Clarity	3.65	58.8%	**GO**
Fun Factor	3.76	64.7%	**PIVOT**
Differentiation	3.88	76.5%	**GO**

G.2 Qualitative Consumer Feedback

To capture the nuances behind the numbers, qualitative responses were categorized into strategic themes.

Table G 3: *Representative Qualitative Quotes and Strategic Insights*

Category	Qualitative Evidence (Raw Quotes)	Strategic Sentiment
Desirability	"It seems unique and helps create bonds with people."	**Positive**
Desirability	"I guess everyone faced with problems when they don't know what they will do on sleepover or smth like that... first that comes to my mind is table games."	**Positive**
Desirability	"It makes people spend time together, break online barriers, and make memories."	**Positive**
Clarity	"Even if something is unclear I can read the instructions."	**Neutral**
Clarity	"I have never played games like on the first picture, and I cannot understand what should I do."	**Negative**
Hygiene	"Since I'm the only one who is going to touch my pieces, I'm okay."	**Conditional**
Hygiene	"They can melt in your hands."	**Negative**
Differentiation	"It's more high quality and gives a reason to buy it often."	**Positive**
Differentiation	"None had a game in the package before."	**Positive**